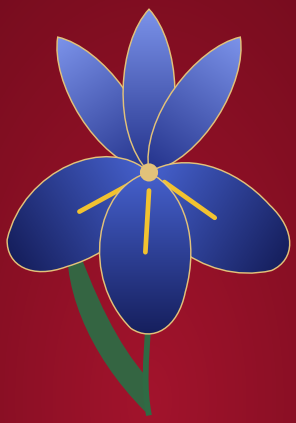
A THESIS IN FOUR PARTS



SUSPIRIUM

Levana's Academy and the Matrices of Sorrow
in Dario Argento and Daria Nicolodi's Suspiria (1977)

TOWARD AN EDUCTIVE THEORY OF THE HORROR IMAGE

MATER LACHRYMARUM · MATER SUSPIRIORUM · MATER TENEBRARUM

They wheeled in mazes; I spelled the steps. They telegraphed from afar; I read the signals. They conspired together; and on the mirrors of darkness my eye traced the plots. Theirs were the symbols; mine are the words.

THOMAS DE QUINCEY · "LEVANA AND OUR LADIES OF SORROW" · 1845

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ABSTRACT

This dissertation contends that *Suspiria* (1977), directed by Dario Argento from a screenplay written with Daria Nicolodi and drawn, without credit, from Thomas De Quincey's prose-poem "Levana and Our Ladies of Sorrow" (*Suspiria de Profundis*, 1845), is not the triumph of sensation over sense that its reception has largely taken it to be, but a rigorously stratified allegory of formation. Its subject is education; its institution is a school; its sovereign is a breath; its medium is suffering light; its catastrophe is a succession. Reconstructing the film's palimpsestic strata — De Quincey's Romantic theodicy of grief and its Jean-Paulian pedagogical source; the contested matrilineal testimony of Nicolodi's grandmother; the fairy-tale grammar of Grimm, Perrault, Collodi, Carroll, Baum and Disney; the comparative mythography of triadic goddesses from the Moirai and Erinyes to the Rhenish Matronae and the Marian *Mater Dolorosa*; the covens of the Romantic ballet; Goethean chromatics and the Technicolor dye-imbibition process; and the Italian and German conjunctures of 1975–1977 — the study advances four interlocking propositions.

The first is **pedagogical**. The Tanz Akademie is a *Levanic institution*, the literalization of De Quincey's claim that Levana educates "not by spelling-books and grammars" but through "passion," "strife," and "the energies of resistance." Suzy Bannion's passage through it inverts the Goethean *Bildungsroman*, whose benevolent secret society, the Society of the Tower, returns as a coven. The second is **pneumatological**. The film's sovereign, Mater Suspiriorum, is principally a breath: the labored sleeping respiration by which she is twice identified, the whispered and panting score, the invisible body betrayed by lightning, the coven that perishes the instant her breath is stopped. *Suspiria* thereby elaborates an infernal counter-pneumatology in which the Pauline Spirit that intercedes "with groanings which cannot be uttered" is refigured as a feminine, sovereign, and unholy *ruach*. The third is **matrical**. The film's color, printed from three dye-imbibition matrices onto a receiving "blank," constitutes what Goethe called the deeds and sufferings of light; the three Mothers are, in a precise material and etymological sense, the matrices of the image, and the academy — founded, the film specifies, in 1895, the year of the cinématographe, the radiograph, and the *Studies on Hysteria* — allegorizes the apparatus that renders the invisible interior visible. The fourth concerns **succession**. The climactic matricide, set within the fire that consumes each of the Mothers' houses across the trilogy, does not purge pity and terror; it completes the Sorrows' commission "to plague his heart until we had unfolded the capacities of his spirit," staging an undecidable scene of inheritance between Julia Kristeva's "vital necessity" of matricide and Luisa Muraro's "symbolic order of the mother."

The dissertation names this structure **eductive horror**: a horror whose operation is not *katharsis* (purgation) but *eductio* (a drawing-forth), and whose spectator, like De Quincey's dreamer, is lifted by Levana in order to be "accomplished in the furnace." Methodologically, the study joins De Quincey's model of the mind as palimpsest to Walter Benjamin's constellational epistemology and Aby Warburg's doctrine of the afterlife of pathos-formulae, and it reads *Suspiria* as a *Trauerspiel* in Technicolor: a mourning-play whose celebrated incoherence is, properly understood, the legibility of its strata.



INTRODUCTION

De Profundis

The Problem, the Thesis, the Method

What else than a natural and mighty palimpsest is the human brain?

DE QUINCEY · "THE PALIMPSEST"

0.1 A film that "makes sense only to the eye"

Suspiria has been praised and dismissed for the same reason: it appears to subordinate meaning to sensation. Its first American reviewers divided along a line that subsequent scholarship has largely preserved, and J. Hoberman's verdict that it is a movie that "makes sense only to the eye" condensed the consensus of admirers and detractors alike. Some complained of gore and a perfunctory plot; others celebrated an assault on the senses without precedent. The academic literature inherits the dichotomy in more sophisticated form. Allmer, Huxley and Brick take the film as an exemplar of European horror whose excess brakes the story so hard that, at intervals, there is no story at all (2012, 14). L. Andrew Cooper locates the ultimate source of meaning in Argento's cinema in aesthetic experience, and argues that the Three Mothers films tie their irrational worlds self-consciously to nineteenth-century Romanticism and the aestheticism that grew from it (2012, 88). Maitland McDonagh reads the Mothers as Jungian archetypes, each sovereign over a city (2010, 29).

These readings are illuminating, but they share an unexamined premise: that sense and sensation are separable quantities whose ratio the film merely tilts. The present study rejects that premise. In *Suspiria*, sensation is not the residue that remains when meaning withdraws. It is the vehicle by which a precise meaning — a theory of formation through sorrow — is delivered, and the manner of

the delivery is itself the meaning. Cooper's observation about Romanticism is therefore the beginning rather than the end of an argument: the film does not merely gesture toward the nineteenth century, it reconstructs one of the nineteenth century's central projects, the education of the subject, and inverts it.

0.2 The thesis: eductive horror

Since Aristotle defined tragedy by the *katharsis* it accomplishes through pity and fear (*Poetics* 1449b), the theory of affective genres has largely operated with purgative or economic models. Horror has been read as purgation; as the staging of abjection, the expulsion of what threatens the borders of the self (Kristeva 1980); as a paradox resolved by curiosity, the cognitive pleasure of disclosing an impossible being (Carroll 1990); as a "body genre" in which the spectator's body mimics the convulsions of the body on screen (Williams 1991). Each model is partly confirmed by *Suspiria*, which purges, abjects, discloses, and convulses. None accounts for its structure.

That structure is announced in the film's source. De Quincey's Levana is the Roman goddess who presided over the lifting of the newborn from the ground, and De Quincey turns her, through a deliberate etymological slide between *edŭco* and *edūco*, into the goddess of education: "Whatsoever educes, or develops, educates." Her instruments are three Sorrows, and their commission, delivered in the prose-poem's final sentence, is "to plague his heart until we had unfolded the capacities of his spirit." I call **eductive** any horror whose operation is not the expulsion of affect but the drawing-forth of capacity; whose violence is curricular rather than cathartic; and whose spectator stands in the position of De Quincey's dreamer, lifted in order to be handed from Sorrow to Sorrow.

Four propositions follow, each developed in a part of the dissertation. The *pedagogical* proposition holds that the Tanz Akademie is a **Levanic institution**, a school whose real curriculum is grief and whose graduation exercise is the killing of its head (Chapters 1, 2, 6). The *pneumatological* proposition holds that the film's sovereign is a breath, so that its metaphysics is a counter-theology of the Spirit; I describe its method, borrowing a term the spiritist Allan Kardec proposed in 1858 for the "direct writing" of spirits first claimed in Europe by Ludwig von Güldenstubbé, as **pneumatography** (Chapters 3, 4). The *matrical* proposition holds that the Mothers are the matrices of the image — literally, in the three dye-imbibition matrices from which the film's color was printed, and philosophically, in the Platonic and Goethean figure of a maternal receptacle of forms — and that color in the film is a **chromatic Passion**, light's suffering made visible (Chapters 5, 7, 8). The *succession* proposition holds that the climactic matricide is not a purgation but a transfer of sovereignty, an event whose undecidability crystallizes the feminist and post-fascist debates of 1977 (Chapters 9, 10).

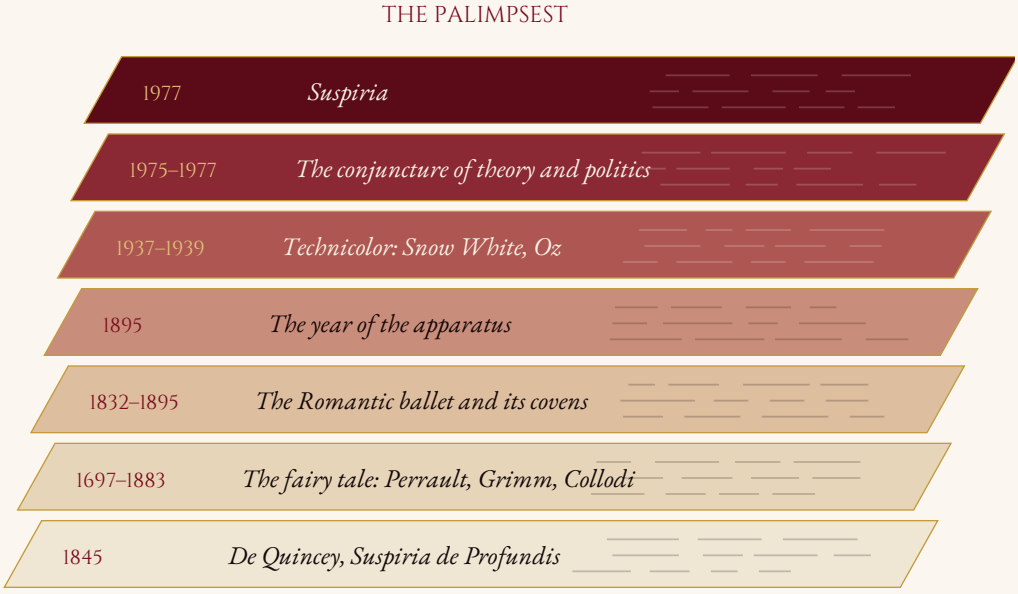
0.3 Method: palimpsest, constellation, afterlife

The method is taken, in the first instance, from the source. In the same collection that contains "Levana," De Quincey asks: "What else than a natural and mighty palimpsest is the human brain?" He answers that "everlasting layers of ideas, images, feelings, have fallen upon your brain softly as light," that each layer "has seemed to bury all that went before," and that "in reality not one has been extin-

guished." A palimpsestic reading therefore treats the film's apparent incoherence not as a failure of narration but as the visible pressure of underlying writings: the Romantic prose-poem, the fairy tale, the grandmother's anecdote, the Technicolor Disney feature, the history of German dance, the conjuncture of the 1970s.

Three further instruments discipline this reading. From Walter Benjamin's *Origin of the German Mourning-Play* (1928) I take the principle that ideas relate to phenomena as constellations relate to stars, and the concept of origin (*Ursprung*) as an eddy in the stream of becoming rather than a point of genesis; from his essays on the mimetic faculty (1933) I take the doctrine of non-sensuous similarity, which licenses attention to correspondences of name, date, and figure. From Aby Warburg I take the concept of *Nachleben*, the afterlife of antiquity, and of the *Pathosformel*, the recurrent expressive formula of the agitated body — the maenad, the nymph in motion, the dancer — whose migrations the *Mnemosyne Atlas* (1924–1929) mapped. The authors' intentions are bracketed in the manner of Wimsatt and Beardsley (1946), but the production record is used wherever it exists, and it is richer than is often acknowledged: Argento's fascination with the border triangle near Basel where Rudolf Steiner built his anthroposophical centre; Nicolodi's debts to *Bluebeard*, *Pinocchio*, and *Alice*; the modelling of the heroine on Snow White; the modelling of the palette on Disney's 1937 feature; and Nicolodi's report that the final sequence came to her in a dream.

To keep constellation from sliding into free association, every correspondence advanced here is assigned to one of three grades. **Grade one** comprises documented sources: texts, films, and testimonies the authors are known to have used. **Grade two** comprises structural homologies that recur at more than one level of the work at once — material, narrative, and mythic — such as the coincidence of three Sorrows, three Mothers, and three dye matrices. **Grade three** comprises conjunctural copresences: texts and events contemporary with the film that share its problem-space without any claim of influence. The argument never promotes a grade-three constellation into a grade-one source, and it says which grade it is using.



"Each succession has seemed to bury all that went before.
And yet in reality not one has been extinguished." — De Quincey

FIGURE 1 *The palimpsest of Suspiria: the strata the dissertation reads beneath the film, oldest at the base. None has been extinguished.*

0.4 The conjuncture of 1975–1977

Suspiria was released in Italy on 1 February 1977, at the end of a brief interval of extraordinary theoretical density. In 1975 Michel Foucault published *Surveiller et punir*, with its anatomy of the boarding school and the docile body; Laura Mulvey published "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema"; Jean-Louis Baudry published "Le dispositif," likening the cinema to Plato's cave and to the regressive state of the dreaming infant; Roland Barthes wrote "En sortant du cinéma," on the hypnotic numbness of the spectator who leaves the dark; Susan Sontag published "Fascinating Fascism"; Pier Paolo Pasolini completed *Salò* and was murdered; Peter Weir released *Picnic at Hanging Rock*; and Argento released *Profondo rosso*, whose killer is a mother. In 1976 Ellen Moers named the "female Gothic," Bruno Bettelheim published *The Uses of Enchantment*, and Luisa Muraro published *La Signora del gioco*, her study of the witch-hunts, while Italian feminists marched under the slogan *Tremate, tremate, le streghe son tornate* — "tremble, tremble, the witches have returned." In 1977 Christian Metz published *Le Signifiant imaginaire*; Wittgenstein's *Remarks on Colour* appeared posthumously; Fritz Leiber's *Our Lady of Darkness* revived De Quincey's third Sorrow in the same year as Argento revived his second; Hans-Jürgen Syberberg released *Hitler, ein Film aus Deutschland*; the police closed Bologna's Radio Alice; and West Germany entered its "German Autumn." Just behind lay

Julia Kristeva's maternal *chora* (1974) and Marija Gimbutas's goddess civilization of Old Europe (1974).

These are grade-three constellations. Their relevance is not that Argento or Nicolodi read them, but that they circle a single problem with remarkable insistence: the relation of a formed subject to the apparatus that forms it, and of that apparatus to a maternal or feminine origin that it both exploits and conceals. *Suspiria* stages that problem as a fairy tale.

0.5 Plan of the work

The dissertation is arranged in four parts. **Part One, "Strata,"** excavates the film's two principal sources: De Quincey's prose-poem and its Romantic pedagogy (Chapter 1), and the matrilineal and fairy-tale substrate contributed by Nicolodi (Chapter 2). **Part Two, "The Mothers,"** situates the triad within a comparative mythography of three-fold goddesses and a modern mythography of the maternal (Chapter 3), and then isolates the film's governing element, breath (Chapter 4). **Part Three, "The Apparatus,"** treats color and its industrial matrices (Chapter 5), dance and the disciplinary pedagogy of grace (Chapter 6), the ocular regime and its overthrow (Chapter 7), and the founding date of 1895 as the key to the film's allegory of cinema (Chapter 8). **Part Four, "The Furnace,"** reads the film within the Italian and German politics of 1977 (Chapter 9) and then follows the fire through the trilogy and its literary antecedents to the matricide and the enigmatic final smile (Chapter 10). A conclusion gathers the argument into ten theses toward a theory of Levanic cinema.

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PART ONE · STRATA

CHAPTER

I

Levana's Commission

De Quincey, Jean Paul, and the Romantic Pedagogy of Sorrow

Whatsoever educes, or develops, educates.

DE QUINCEY · "LEVANA AND OUR LADIES OF SORROW"

De Quincey supplied Argento and Nicolodi not merely with three names but with a complete institutional grammar — a hidden sovereign who acts by delegation, a curriculum of grief, a choreography of signs, and a terminus in fire — and the film follows that grammar with a fidelity its uncredited status has obscured.

1.1 Sighs from the depths: title, psalm, genre

Suspiria de Profundis appeared in *Blackwood's Edinburgh Magazine* in 1845 as the sequel to the *Confessions of an English Opium-Eater* (1821). Its title grafts the Latin plural of *suspirium* onto the incipit of Psalm 129 in the Vulgate numbering (130 in the Hebrew), *De profundis clamavi ad te, Domine*, the sixth of the seven penitential psalms and a fixture of the Office of the Dead; in Catholic Italy the *De profundis* is the prayer said for the departed. To sigh "from the depths" is therefore to perform a liturgy of the dead in the register of breath rather than voice: not the psalmist's cry (*clamavi*) but the sub-vocal exhalation, *suspirium*, from *sub* and *spirare*, "to breathe from beneath." The film kept the first word and suppressed the second. It kept the breath and buried the depths, which return, as the buried always return in a palimpsest, as the chambers behind Madame Blanc's office.

De Quincey called such pieces "impassioned prose," a genre suspended between essay, dream-record, and liturgy, and he conceived *Suspiria* as a larger architecture than he completed. The published sequence sets the meditation on the palimpsest of the brain and the portrait of Levana beside "The Apparition of the Brocken," an account of the optical spectre seen on the Harz summit where German tradition gathers the witches on Walpurgis Night. The juxtaposition is already a program. Within one collection De Quincey placed the Mothers of sorrow beside a natural cinema — the viewer's own shadow projected, enlarged and haloed, onto mist — on the mountain that Goethe's *Faust* had made the theatre of the witches' sabbath. The collection's opening section, "The Affliction of Childhood," recounts the death of the author's sister Elizabeth and coins the term "involutes" for the compound experiences in which "our deepest thoughts and feelings" reach us folded into concrete objects that cannot be disentangled from them. Argento's set-pieces are involutes in exactly this sense: the murder of Pat Hingle cannot be separated from the stained glass through which it passes, nor Daniel's death from the square in which it occurs.

1.2 Levana: rite, etymology, pedagogy

Levana belongs to the swarm of minor Roman tutelary powers, each presiding over an instant of infancy, that Varro catalogued and Augustine ridiculed (*De civitate Dei* IV.11). Her office was the lifting, *levare*, of the newborn from the earth on which it had been laid; Augustine's Latin is "ipse levet de terra et vocetur dea Levana," let the god lift the child from the earth and be called the goddess Levana. De Quincey, following a long antiquarian tradition, reads the gesture as a father's acknowledgment of his child: "At the very moment of birth, just as the infant tasted for the first time the atmosphere of our troubled planet, it was laid on the ground," and then "either the paternal hand, as proxy for the goddess Levana, or some near kinsman, as proxy for the father, raised it upright, bade it look erect as the king of all this world, and presented its forehead to the stars."

Three features of this account become structural in the film. The first is that the infant's initiation begins with "atmosphere," with a first breath: Levana's rite is respiratory before it is pedagogical. The second is that the goddess "never revealed her face (except to me in dreams), but always acted by delegation." The paternal hand is her proxy and the kinsman is the father's proxy: a chain of delegation descending from an invisible sovereign. This is precisely the governance of the Tanz Akademie, whose directress is said to be away, whose deputy headmistress (Madame Blanc) and head instructor (Miss Tanner) administer in her name, and whose servants — Pavlos, the cook, the boy Albert — are proxies of proxies. Markos, like Levana, is never seen except in a kind of dream, and by lightning. The third feature is the etymological slide on which the whole essay turns: "the word *edŭco*, with the penultimate short, was derived ... from the word *edūco*, with the penultimate long. Whatsoever educes, or develops, educates." Education is not instruction but the drawing-forth of what is latent, and De Quincey immediately names its means: "not the poor machinery that moves by spelling-books and grammars, but by that mighty system of central forces hidden in the deep bosom of human life, which by passion, by strife, by temptation, by the energies of resistance, works forever upon children."

Modern scholarship is more cautious about the rite than De Quincey was, and its caution strengthens the argument. The evidence for a ceremony in which the father lifted the newborn to acknowledge it as his own is tenuous and sits uneasily with Roman law on legitimacy; it is more likely that Levana presided over the lifting of the newborn by the midwife, immediately after a birth in which the mother knelt or squatted and the child came to rest on the ground. If so, the paternal reading De Quincey inherited is itself a palimpsest, a father's gesture written over a woman's: the original act of formation in the Levana cult belonged to the hands of the woman who delivered the child, exactly as the film's auteurist signature is written over Nicolodi's matrilineal sources (Chapter 2). The witch-hunters knew where that power lay. The *Malleus maleficarum* (1486) singles out midwives among witches, charging that they kill children in the womb or offer newborns to the devil, and Barbara Ehrenreich and Deirdre English's *Witches, Midwives, and Nurses* (1973) made the persecution of women healers a founding argument of 1970s feminist history. Levana's office — the lifting of the newborn by the woman who brought it into the world — is the office that the witch-hunt criminalized, and it is the office the Mothers of *Suspiria* pervert: they too lift the girl from the ground, but in order to hand her to sorrow.

The name came to De Quincey from Jean Paul Richter, whose *Levana oder Erziehlehre* (1807) is a founding treatise of Romantic pedagogy — published in the same year as Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit*, which narrates the education of consciousness along a "path of despair." De Quincey had translated Jean Paul in the 1820s and knew his work intimately. Jean Paul's *Levana*, heir to Rousseau's *Émile* (1762), defends the child's inner life, play, and religious sense against the mechanical drill of the Enlightenment schoolroom. De Quincey keeps the hostility to "spelling-books and grammars" but replaces the cultivation of joy with a cultivation of grief: his Levana "dotes upon grief." The darkening is decisive. It converts the Romantic critique of institutional pedagogy into an affirmation of an older and harsher institution, suffering itself, as the true school.

De Quincey anchors the point in a real institution. "The rules of Eton require that a boy on the foundation should be there twelve years: he is superannuated at eighteen; consequently he must come at six. Children torn away from mothers and sisters at that age not unfrequently die." The founding text of the trilogy is thus, among other things, an indictment of the boarding school as a place where children separated from their mothers die of grief. The film moves this pedagogy from Eton's foundation boys to a dance school's girls, and from death by grief to death by murder, but the institution — residential, separating the child from the mother, educating in sorrow — is De Quincey's.

1.3 The Sorrows: typology, gait, and the silence of signs

De Quincey introduces the Sorrows through a typology of triads: they are three, "as the Graces are three, who dress man's life with beauty; the Parcae are three, who weave the dark arras of man's life in their mysterious loom always with colours sad in part, sometimes angry with tragic crimson and black; the Furies are three, who visit with retributions called from the other side of the grave offences that walk upon this; and once even the Muses were but three." Two consequences follow. The Sorrows absorb four functions — beauty, destiny, retribution, art — and an academy of dance is exactly

an institution that combines them: it beautifies bodies, assigns them destinies, punishes them, and makes them art. And De Quincey's Fates already weave in color, in "tragic crimson and black," which is the chromatic key of the film before a single gel has been lit.

The Sorrows do not speak. "Mighty phantoms like these disdain the infirmities of language. ... eternal silence reigns in their kingdoms." They communicate "not by sounds that perish, or by words that go astray, but by signs in heaven, by changes on Earth, by pulses in secret rivers, heraldries painted on darkness, and hieroglyphics written on the tablets of the brain. They wheeled in mazes; I spelled the steps. They telegraphed from afar; I read the signals. They conspired together; and on the mirrors of darkness my eye traced the plots. Theirs were the symbols; mine are the words." This is a media theory *avant la lettre*. It names choreography, for the Sorrows dance and the dreamer reads their dance as a script; telegraphy, a metaphor current in 1845, the year after Morse's line between Washington and Baltimore opened; projection, in heraldries painted on darkness and plots traced on mirrors of darkness; inscription upon the brain; and conspiracy, the plotting of a coven. Its last sentence assigns the image to the Sorrows and the word to the dreamer, a division of labor the film reproduces with uncanny exactness. *Suspiria*'s dialogue is its weakest stratum — dubbed, stilted, often inert — while its images and sounds carry the argument. The Sorrows, De Quincey had warned, disdain the infirmities of language.

The Sorrows also move, and their gaits form a choreographic taxonomy. "Madonna moves with uncertain steps, fast or slow, but still with tragic grace. Our Lady of Sighs creeps timidly and stealthily. But this youngest Sister moves with incalculable motions, bounding, and with tiger's leaps." Adagio, stealthy glide, and *grand jeté*: the Mothers are dancers before they are witches.

The portraits supply the rest. Mater Lachrymarum "night and day raves and moans, calling for vanished faces"; she stood in Rama, "where a voice was heard of lamentation — Rachel weeping for her children, and refusing to be comforted," and in Bethlehem "on the night when Herod's sword swept its nurseries of Innocents, and the little feet were stiffened forever" — the massacre of the town's infant boys that Matthew's Gospel attributes to King Herod (Matthew 2:16), which De Quincey names in the very vocabulary of Levana's office, the nursery; she wears a diadem and "carries keys more than papal at her girdle." One detail matters especially for the film. She sat "by the bedside of the blind beggar" whose "pious daughter, eight years old," guided him along the roads until she died; "still he dreams at midnight that the little guiding hand is locked within his own; and still he wakens to a darkness that is now within a second and a deeper darkness." The blind man bereft of his guide anticipates Daniel, the academy's blind pianist, whose guide turns killer, and the guiding child's age, eight, coincides with the age at which Argento and Nicolodi first imagined their students. This is a grade-two homology: it recurs in the narrative and in the production history at once.

Mater Suspiriorum wears no diadem but "a dilapidated turban"; her eyes, if seen, "would be found filled with perishing dreams, and with wrecks of forgotten delirium." "She weeps not. She groans not. But she sighs inaudibly at intervals." She is "humble to abjectness"; hers is "the meekness that belongs to the hopeless." "Murmur she may, but it is in her sleep." She is the visitor of "the Pariah, of the Jew, of the bondsman to the oar in the Mediterranean galleys; of the English criminal in Norfolk Island" — the penal settlement in the South Pacific notorious for the brutality of its regime; of the enslaved man who points "with one hand to the earth, our general mother, but for him a step-

mother," and with the other "to the Bible, our general teacher, but against him sealed and sequestered"; of "every woman sitting in darkness, without love to shelter her head," whose stifled instincts "burn sullenly to waste, like sepulchral lamps," and of "every nun defrauded of her unreturning May-time." She "carries a key; but she needs it little." Mater Tenebrarum, the youngest, is approached in a whisper; her head is "turreted like that of Cybele," she wears "a treble veil of crape," she is "the defier of God," "the mother of lunacies, and the suggestress of suicides," whose power reaches only those "in whom a profound nature has been upheaved by central convulsions," and she carries no key because she "storms all doors."

Three details in these portraits bear directly on the argument, and the first version of this chapter compressed them. The Lady of Sighs visits the enslaved man for whom the earth is "our general mother, but for him a stepmother," and the Bible "our general teacher, but against him sealed": De Quincey's catalogue already contains the split that Bettelheim would find in the fairy tale (Chapter 2), between the true mother and the stepmother, and between the teacher who forms and the teacher who excludes. Her dominion includes the convict of Norfolk Island, a penal colony, so that the Sorrows govern the very institution of punishment that Kafka would turn into an apparatus of education by wounds (Chapter 6). And the third Sister is "the suggestress of suicides": in De Quincey, Darkness rules the mind broken from within, the domain to which Chapter 9 returns through Kristeva's account of melancholy as the failure to separate from the mother.

Argento's decisive act is a transvaluation. He gives Freiburg, and the first film, to the meekest of the three, and he makes her the most powerful; the trilogy's later lore names her eldest and wisest, the Black Queen. Humility "to abjectness" becomes the sovereignty of the abject. The inaudible sigh becomes the audible, labored breath of an ancient sleeping body. And the population De Quincey assigns her — outcasts, women whose desire has been stifled into slow-burning ash, nuns defrauded of their youth — becomes her coven. The coven is De Quincey's catalogue of stifled women given a constitution.

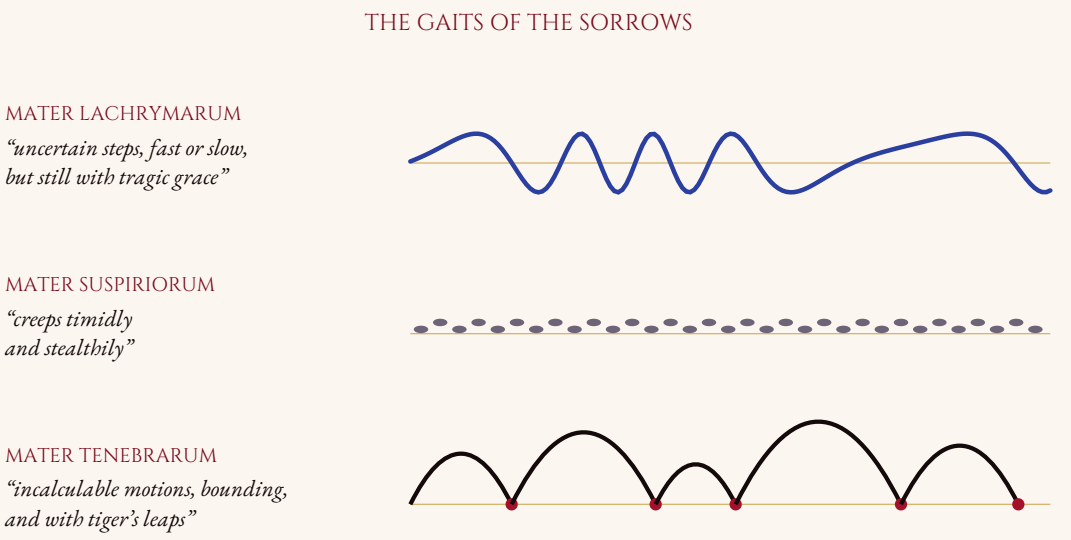


FIGURE 2 *The gaits of the Sorrows, after De Quincey: a choreography in three hands, adagio, glide and leap.*

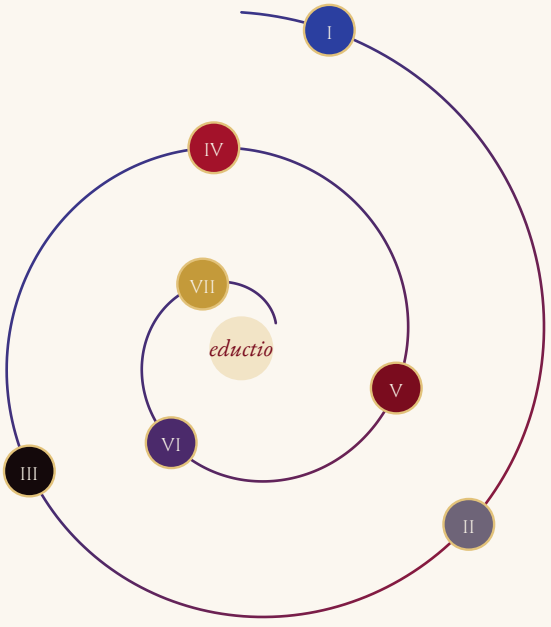
1.4 The commission: theodicy as curriculum

The prose-poem ends with a speech. Our Lady of Tears, touching the dreamer's head, hands him to her sisters: "Him, this young idolater, I have seasoned for thee, dear gentle Sister of Sighs! Do thou take him now to thy heart, and season him for our dreadful sister. And thou ... wicked sister, that temptest and hatest, do thou take him from her. ... Suffer not woman and her tenderness to sit near him in his darkness. ... So shall he be accomplished in the furnace; so shall he see the things that ought not to be seen, sights that are abominable, and secrets that are unutterable. So shall he read elder truths, sad truths, grand truths, fearful truths. So shall he rise again before he dies. And so shall our commission be accomplished which from God we had — to plague his heart until we had unfolded the capacities of his spirit."

This is a syllabus. Its stations are dedication, seasoning, the withering of hope under a heavy sceptre, the furnace, the forbidden vision, the reading of elder truths, resurrection before death, and, as telos, the unfolding of capacity. It is a theodicy converted into a curriculum: suffering is justified not by future compensation, as in Leibniz's *Théodicée* (1710), but by its formative yield. M. H. Abrams described the great Romantic plot as a secularized theodicy in which the mind educates itself through loss along a circuitous journey (1971); De Quincey's commission is its most compressed and most pitiless statement. The film follows the syllabus with startling precision. Suzy is dedicated (admitted), seasoned (hexed, drugged, nourished with the wine), placed under darkness (the deaths of Pat, Daniel and Sara, the withdrawal of every tenderness), brought to see what ought not to be seen (the coven in session, Sara's mutilated corpse), confronted with the elder truth (the ancient Mother), and brought out of the furnace alive.

Two variations matter. Because the pupil is a girl and the teachers are women, the injunction "Suffer not woman and her tenderness to sit near him in his darkness" becomes, in the film, the systematic destruction of every bond between women except the bond with the Mother. And "from God" disappears. Argento's Mothers hold no commission from above; their pedagogy is immanent and self-legitimating, a theodicy without *theos*. What remains is the furnace.

De Quincey calls the Sorrows "the Semnai Theai or Sublime Goddesses ... the Eumenides or Gracious Ladies (so called by antiquity in shuddering propitiation)," the euphemistic titles of Aeschylus' Furies after their reconciliation at the end of the *Oresteia*, where they are granted a dwelling beneath the Areopagus. The detail anticipates the film's architecture: chthonic powers lodged behind an institution of the city, honored and hidden at once.



I · DEDICATION
in the keeping of Tears

II · SEASONING
handed to the Sister of Sighs

III
The withering of hope
under the sceptre of Darkness

IV
Accomplished in the furnace
the trial by fire

V
The forbidden sight
"things that ought not to be seen"

VI · ELDER TRUTHS
"sad truths, grand truths, fearful truths"

VII
Rising again before death
"so shall he rise again"

"to plague his heart until we had unfolded the capacities of his spirit"

FIGURE 3 *The commission as curriculum: De Quincey's seven stations read as a descending spiral whose centre is eductio, the drawing-forth of capacity.*

1.5 Murder as a fine art, and the knocking at the gate

Two other essays by De Quincey bear on Argento as directly as "Levana." "On Murder Considered as One of the Fine Arts" (1827, with supplements of 1839 and 1854) imagines a Society of Connoisseurs in Murder that judges homicides by aesthetic criteria and takes as its masterpiece the Ratcliffe Highway murders of December 1811, in which seven people in two East London households, an in-

fant among them, were killed. The killings were attributed to a seaman, John Williams, who was found hanged in his cell before he could be tried, so that his guilt was never tested in court; T. A. Critchley and P. D. James later argued that he may have been innocent (1971). De Quincey's connoisseurship thus takes as its exemplary object the killing of a family, a child included, and its attribution to a man no court convicted. The satire divides aesthetic from moral judgment so cleanly that it ceases to be only satire: it inaugurates the modern aesthetics of violence that runs through Baudelaire and Wilde to the *giallo*. Argento's set-pieces, whose lingering construction Peter Bondanella identified as a signature (2009, 323), are the connoisseurship De Quincey parodied, now practised with the irony relocated from the text to the spectator, who is invited to admire and to recoil in the same instant.

"On the Knocking at the Gate in *Macbeth*" (1823) is the deeper influence, though it is never cited. De Quincey asks why the knocking after Duncan's murder produces such awe, and answers that the murderers' interval constitutes a world withdrawn from human time, which the knocking ends: "the human has made its reflux upon the fiendish; the pulses of life are beginning to beat again." *Suspiria* opens with this structure inverted. Suzy arrives at night in a storm and rings at the academy's door; the voice on the intercom — Sara's, as she later confesses — refuses her; Pat Hingle flees past her into the rain crying fragments; and the murder follows elsewhere. The knocking precedes the deed and is denied. The human cannot make its reflux; the fiendish interval opens instead of closing; and the pulse that will beat again at the end is not the restoration of ordinary life but the heartbeat of a girl who has passed through fire. That the essay concerns *Macbeth*, a play governed by three weird sisters, completes the circuit: De Quincey's two great triadic texts, the Sorrows and the witches, converge in Argento's film.

The aesthetic frame is the Burkean sublime, with its thesis that terror is the ruling principle of the sublime and its catalogue of privations — darkness, vacuity, solitude, silence (Burke 1757). De Quincey extended the sublime into architecture. In the *Confessions* he reports Coleridge's description of Piranesi's *Carceri*, staircases climbing without end with the artist himself toiling up each flight. Argento's academy, and still more the Varelli houses of *Inferno*, are Piranesian in this sense: buildings whose interiors exceed their exteriors, in which a door in an office opens onto a world.

H. P. Lovecraft's "The Dreams in the Witch House" (1933) gave the Piranesian witch-house its modern, mathematical form; the first version of this chapter cut it for length. A university student lodges in the Arkham house where the seventeenth-century witch Keziah Mason had lived, and discovers that its irregular angles open onto other dimensions through which she and her familiar still move; on Walpurgis Night they abduct a child for sacrifice. The witch's power is architectural before it is personal: a house whose geometry exceeds its walls. Varelli's houses in *Inferno* are of this kind, and the Tanz Akademie, whose office door gives onto an interior larger than the building seems to hold, is their first instance.

1.6 Relay: Baudelaire and the continental afterlife

De Quincey reached the continental imagination chiefly through Baudelaire, whose "Un mangeur d'opium," in *Les Paradis artificiels* (1860), translates, paraphrases and glosses the *Confessions* and the

Suspiria, Levana included. Baudelaire brought to De Quincey his own doctrine of *correspondances* — "les parfums, les couleurs et les sons se répondent," perfumes, colors and sounds answer one another — which recasts the Sorrows' silent signs as a synesthetic system; critics have traced the triadic structure of "Levana" into "Le Cygne." The relay matters because *Suspiria*'s synesthesia, a score composed before the shooting and colors that behave like sounds, is Baudelairean before it is Quinceyan: it reaches De Quincey's Sorrows through the French poet's correspondences. In the Anglophone world the relay ran through the pulps. Fritz Leiber's *Our Lady of Darkness*, published in 1977, quotes "Levana" and makes Mater Tenebrarum the antagonist of a San Francisco urban occultism. That De Quincey's second and third Sorrows were reanimated in the same year, independently, by an Italian filmmaker and an American fantasist is a grade-three constellation, but a telling one: 1977 was the year the Ladies of Sorrow returned.

1.7 What the film takes, and what it transforms

From De Quincey the film takes the triad and its Latin names; the invisible sovereign who acts by delegation; the residential institution that educates by grief; the blind man bereft of his guide; the Sorrow who murmurs in her sleep; the media of the Sorrows — dance, signal, projection on darkness, inscription upon the brain; the Eumenides lodged beneath the city; and the furnace. It transforms the pupil's sex, from a male opium-eater to a female dancer; the dream into an institution; the divine commission into an immanent sovereignty; the meekest Sorrow into the Black Queen; and, most consequentially, the passive dreamer who merely "spelled the steps" into an agent who reads the signs — Pat's three words, Sara's counted footsteps — and acts upon them. That last transformation is the hinge of the dissertation. Suzy is De Quincey's dreamer made to wake inside the dream, and the dream's curriculum, once completed, leaves her not a broken visionary but a sovereign.

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PART ONE · STRATA

CHAPTER

II

The Grandmother's Academy

Matrilineal Authorship and the Fairy-Tale Substrate

…the tutelary power that controls the education of the nursery.

DE QUINCEY · "LEVANA"

If De Quincey gave *Suspiria* its grammar, Daria Nicolodi gave it its genre — the fairy tale — received through a chain of women whose authority the auteurist signature has persistently effaced, and the film's own structure, a visible delegated order fronting an invisible feminine origin, reproduces the structure of its authorship.

2.1 Authorship as coven

The screenplay credit reads Dario Argento and Daria Nicolodi, and accounts of the production report that Nicolodi had to fight for it. The production record assigns her three contributions that are not peripheral but constitutive: the fairy-tale models (*Bluebeard*, *Pinocchio*, *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland*); the anecdote of her grandmother's encounter with black magic at a music academy; and the dream from which the final sequence was drawn. She was also to have played Sara, the friend who confides in Suzy and dies in a pit of razor wire, and was prevented only by an injury. The co-author was thus displaced from the role of the murdered confidante — a displacement that the film, with its systematic destruction of bonds between women, could hardly have scripted better.

The *politique des auteurs*, from Truffaut's polemic of 1954 to Andrew Sarris's auteur theory of 1962, made the director's name the paternal guarantor of a film's unity. Barthes's "The Death of the

Author" (1967) attacked that guarantee from the side of the reader. *Suspiria* poses a different problem: not the death of the Author but the burial of a co-author, a woman's hand written over by a man's name. The palimpsest is literal. Its lower writing is matrilineal — a grandmother's memorate, a granddaughter's screenplay — and the trilogy itself eventually exhumes it. In *The Mother of Tears* (2007), Nicolodi plays the spectral mother of the heroine, a white witch who guides her daughter against the third Mother, and the daughter is played by Asia Argento, Nicolodi's own daughter. The film's backstory goes further. Elisa had challenged and gravely wounded Mater Suspiriorum before the events of the first film, and the Mother retaliated by killing Elisa and her husband; Suzy's victory in 1977 is thus retroactively shared with the character played by the first film's co-author, who weakened the Mother before the American girl arrived. The last film of the trilogy writes the co-author of the first into its mythology as the good mother and as Suzy's unseen predecessor, and three real generations of women — grandmother, mother, daughter — stand behind the three fictional Mothers as their benign counter-triad.

2.2 Memorate, fabulate, disavowal

The Swedish folklorist Carl Wilhelm von Sydow distinguished the *memorate*, a first-person account of a supernatural encounter, from the *fabulate*, a traditional narrative shaped by repetition into fiction (1934). Nicolodi's grandmother's story — she had gone to an unnamed academy for a piano lesson, believed she had encountered black magic there, and fled in terror — is a memorate; the film is the fabulate into which it was converted. Argento later declared the story invented. That disavowal belongs to the legend's structure rather than refuting it: within the film, the psychiatrist Frank Mandel performs the same gesture, reducing witchcraft to a disorder of minds. The male voice of reason denies the female testimony, and the testimony survives the denial by becoming a myth.

The anecdote's elements reappear in the film with structural exactness: an academy, a music lesson (the blind pianist Daniel), a girl who flees in terror (Pat Hingle), black magic. Its literary analogue is Arthur Machen's "The White People" (1904), whose "Green Book" records a girl's initiation by her nurse into a secret feminine lore, a transmission of occult knowledge from an older woman to a child that ends, as the story's frame reports, with the girl found dead, having poisoned herself. Like De Quincey's Levana, who never shows her face "except to me in dreams," the grandmother is witnessed only in memory. And the anecdote has an institutional horizon in the production record. Argento has said that the idea of the film came to him on a journey through Lyon, Prague, and Turin, and that he became fascinated by the border triangle where France, Germany, and Switzerland meet, the region where Rudolf Steiner founded his anthroposophical community at Dornach. Whatever the truth of the grandmother's story, the occult school of the Upper Rhine is a grade-one source.

2.3 The nursery and the problem of scale

The students were originally conceived as girls of eight to ten. When the producers balked, the ages were raised, but the sets reportedly kept a child's proportions, with door handles placed at the height of the actresses' heads; one reviewer in 1977 complained that Jessica Harper had been costumed to

look much younger than her years. The abandoned conception is not an anecdote but a key. De Quincey had defined Levana as "the tutelary power that controls the education of the nursery," and the eight-year-old guiding daughter of his blind beggar sits at the center of his portrait of Tears. The film's first design literalized the nursery; its final design preserved the nursery's optics, so that adult women move through a house built for giants.

The proximate source of this optics is Carroll's *Alice* (1865), which Nicolodi named. Alice falls into a world of doors too small or too large and drinks from a bottle labelled "DRINK ME" that alters her scale; Suzy enters a world of disproportionate doors and drinks a wine that alters her consciousness. The deeper frame is Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919), whose philology shows the *heimlich*, the homely, turning by degrees into its opposite, so that the most familiar house becomes the most estranged. Gaston Bachelard's *Poetics of Space* (1958) supplies the topology. For Bachelard the house is vertical: the attic is the zone of rational clarity, the cellar "the dark entity of the house," the seat of the irrational. *Suspiria* inverts the scheme. Corruption rains down from the attic, where spoiled food breeds maggots that fall through the ceilings, and the attic is where Sara is hunted. The coven's sanctum lies not in a cellar but behind the deputy headmistress's office: the irrational is lodged at the administrative center of the institution. The hidden rooms exceed the house that contains them — an instance of what Bachelard called "intimate immensity," here turned malign.

2.4 Morphology of a witch-tale

Vladimir Propp's *Morphology of the Folktale* (1928) reduced the Russian wonder tale to thirty-one functions in fixed sequence, and *Suspiria* follows that sequence closely enough to be read as a modern instance of it. The heroine is far from home (absentation). She is watched by the villain's agents — the cook and the boy Albert in the corridor, a scene cut as a hex (reconnaissance). Information passes to and from her: Pat's fragmentary words, Sara's confidences (delivery). She is deceived into ingesting something that binds her — the prescribed wine at dinner (trickery and complicity). That last function is the hinge of the whole morphology, and its avatars include Snow White's apple, Persephone's pomegranate seeds, Alice's bottle, and the doctored mousse of *Rosemary's Baby* (1968), with which Rosemary's elderly neighbors, the leaders of a coven, drug her so that she can be raped during their ritual, with her husband's connivance, in exchange for his career. Murders follow (villainy). Donors provide knowledge: Sara, Mandel, the occultist Milius. A magical agent is acquired: the secret of the iris and, at the last, the glass quill. There is a struggle, a victory, and a departure. Propp's final function is that "the hero is married and ascends the throne." The film omits the wedding and keeps the throne — the first indication that its ending is an accession rather than an escape.

Bruno Bettelheim's *The Uses of Enchantment* (1976), published the year before the film, argued that fairy tales educate children by staging their fears, and that the tale splits the mother into a good mother, usually dead, and a wicked stepmother or witch who embodies the child's ambivalence. The Grimms' second edition of 1819 states that children's tales are told so that in their pure and gentle light "die ersten Gedanken und Kräfte des Herzens aufwachen und wachsen," the first thoughts and powers of the heart may awaken and grow — Levana's eduction in the vocabulary of the nursery — and its preface hopes that the collection will become a true *Erziehungsbuch*, a book of upbringing.

The fairy tale is Levana's genre: education through terror, administered in the nursery. Of the Grimms' tales, two bear directly on the film. In "Snow White," on which the production record says Suzy was modelled, a narcissistic queen-witch tries to destroy a girl whose beauty threatens her sovereignty, and fails. In "Hansel and Gretel," the witch's house is edible, the children are fattened for consumption, and it is the girl, not the boy, who tricks the witch into the oven and burns her. Freiburg is the gateway to the Black Forest, the landscape of the Grimms' imaginary.

Bettelheim himself belongs to this history, and the first version of this chapter passed over him. From 1944 to 1973 he directed the Sonia Shankman Orthogenic School at the University of Chicago, a residential institution for disturbed children that he presented as a humane therapeutic milieu. In *The Empty Fortress* (1967) he attributed infantile autism to cold, rejecting parenting, chiefly by mothers, and likened the autistic child's withdrawal to the condition of a prisoner in the camps, which he had known at Dachau and Buchenwald; the theory, popularized under the label "refrigerator mother," placed the blame for their children's condition on a generation of mothers and is now rejected. After his death in 1990, former residents and counselors stated publicly that he had hit children and governed the school through fear and humiliation. Richard Pollak's biography (1997), written by the brother of a former resident, documented these accounts together with misrepresentations of Bettelheim's credentials, while Nina Sutton's biography (1996) and some former staff defended him; Alan Dundes argued that parts of *The Uses of Enchantment* drew without acknowledgment on Julius Heuscher's *A Psychiatric Study of Fairy Tales* (1963). The correspondence is a grade-three constellation, not a claim of influence, but its structure is exact: the theorist who taught that children are formed through fairy-tale fear, and who made the mother the cause of a child's retreat into a fortress, directed a residential school that, by these accounts, ran on fear behind a benevolent pedagogy. The Levanic institution is not only a fiction.

Collodi's *Pinocchio* (1883), the most Italian of the film's sources, is a *Bildungsroman* of a marionette. A wooden puppet must be educated, through school and suffering, into "a real boy." His guide is the Fairy with turquoise hair, who first appears at a window as a dead child awaiting her coffin; later Pinocchio finds a tombstone declaring that she died of sorrow at being abandoned by him; later still she returns as his mother. A maternal fairy dead of grief and resurrected as mother; a puppet-master named Fire-Eater who nearly burns the hero for firewood; a seductive institution, the Land of Toys, that turns boys into donkeys: Collodi supplies the film's puppet logic (Chapter 6) and its blue-haired mother of grief, whose color returns as the blue iris that opens the Mother's door.

Perrault's "Bluebeard" (1697) supplies the forbidden chamber — where Bluebeard keeps the bodies of the wives he has murdered — and its key, which, once used, bears a stain of blood that cannot be washed away: the proof, readable by the husband, that his new wife now knows. Fritz Lang's *Secret Beyond the Door* (1947), a Bluebeard noir, starred Joan Bennett as the bride who opens the locked room. Thirty years later Bennett, in her last film role, plays Madame Blanc, who guards it; the actress crosses from transgressor to guardian of the same threshold. Angela Carter's "The Bloody Chamber" (1979) rewrote Bluebeard so that the heroine's mother rides to her rescue and shoots the murderer. Between 1977 and 1979 the two great late-twentieth-century revisions of the tale thus divided its maternal possibilities between them: in Carter the mother saves the daughter from the house; in *Suspiria* the mother is the house.

2.5 The American girl among the witches

The most consequential American fairy tale behind the film is *The Wonderful Wizard of Oz*. Its author, L. Frank Baum, was the son-in-law of Matilda Joslyn Gage, whose *Woman, Church and State* (1893) read the European witch-hunts as a war on women; Baum's good witches carry that revisionism into children's literature (1900). The MGM film of 1939, printed by the same Technicolor imbibition process later used for *Suspiria*, gave the tale its canonical color. Its plot is the film's: an American girl, carried by a storm into a foreign land governed by witches, kills a witch, and unmasks a hidden sovereign who rules through an amplified voice behind a curtain. Suzy arrives in a thunderstorm, kills a witch, and unmasks a sovereign who rules through breath and voice from behind a wall.

The American girl in Europe is also a Jamesian figure. In *Daisy Miller* (1878) the innocent American dies of Roman fever; in *The Portrait of a Lady* (1881) Isabel Archer is delivered into a disastrous marriage by Madame Merle, an older European woman acting for a hidden master. Madame Merle (the blackbird) and Madame Blanc (the white) are counterparts across a century: older women who manage an American girl's European education on behalf of a power they do not name. James's "international theme" — New World freedom encountering Old World corruption — is restaged in *Suspiria* as the encounter of an American individualism with an archaic European matriarchy.

The casting deepens the palimpsest. Joan Bennett brings Lang's noirs and the matriarch she played in the gothic serial *Dark Shadows*. Alida Valli brings *Senso*, *The Third Man*, and above all *Eyes Without a Face* (1960), in which she played the assistant who lures young women to a surgeon who removes their faces — a woman who procures girls for a hidden master. Udo Kier brings the Frankenstein and Dracula of the Warhol-Morrissey films. Jessica Harper, cast on the strength of *Phantom of the Paradise* (1974), brings the role of Phoenix, a singer bound by contract to a demonic impresario named Swan. The actors arrive already written upon. When Harper's Suzy walks out of the burning academy at the end, she completes the name of her previous role.

Nicolodi's substrate makes *Suspiria* a fairy tale in Propp's strict sense, one whose terminal function is enthronement, and it turns De Quincey's commission into a children's story. The fusion is the film's originality: Levana's curriculum told as *Snow White*.

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PART TWO · THE MOTHERS

CHAPTER

III

Triplicities

A Comparative Mythography of the Three Mothers

These are the Sorrows; and they are three in number.

DE QUINCEY · "LEVANA"

The Three Mothers belong to a family of triadic feminine powers that runs from Hesiod's Moirai to Robert Graves's Triple Goddess, but they are distinguished within it by one feature: they are not functional but affective, three phase-states of a single sorrow, and the element that destroys each of them is the missing fourth.

3.1 Why three?

Hermann Usener's "Dreiheit" (1903) gathered the triads of ancient religion and argued that three had once signified totality. Georges Dumézil's trifunctional hypothesis (1958) read Indo-European ideology as a structure of sovereignty, force, and fecundity. Neither model fits the Mothers, whose division is not among social functions but among modes of grief. The more useful precedent is Freud's "The Theme of the Three Caskets" (1913). Considering the choice among three caskets in *The Merchant of Venice*, among three daughters in *King Lear*, and among three goddesses in the judgment of Paris, Freud concludes that the third figure, silent and pale, is Death; that the three sisters are the Moirai, the Norns, the Horae; and that the triad represents the forms the figure of the mother takes across a man's life — the mother who bears him, the beloved chosen in her image, and Mother Earth who receives him again. Myth, Freud argues, converts the necessity of death into a free choice of love.

Freud's triad is organized around a man's relations to women. De Quincey's, though addressed to a male dreamer, is a sequence not of relations but of sorrows. Argento's, addressed to a girl, removes the male term altogether: the heroine's relation to the Mothers is neither erotic nor filial but successional. Freud's silent third survives, however. It is De Quincey's Tenebrarum, of whom one must whisper, and it is the Mother of Sighs, whose speech has dwindled into breath.

3.2 Greek triads

The Moirai receive a double genealogy within a single poem: Hesiod makes them daughters of Night (*Theogony* 217–222) and, later, daughters of Zeus and Themis (904–906). The doubling stages in miniature the transition, central to nineteenth-century mythography, from chthonic to Olympian authority. Clotho spins, Lachesis allots, Atropos cuts; De Quincey's Parcae weave in "tragic crimson and black."

The Erinyes — Alecto, Tisiphone, Megaera — are born of Earth from the blood of the castrated Ouranos (*Theogony* 185). In Aeschylus' *Eumenides* they pursue Orestes for the murder of his mother. Apollo argues that the mother is not the parent of the child but only the nurse of the seed the father sows; Athena, born from no mother, casts the deciding vote for acquittal; and the Furies, persuaded, become the Semnai Theai, the Venerable Goddesses, housed in a cavern beneath the Areopagus. Matricide is acquitted, mother-right subordinated, and the avenging mothers honored and buried at once. De Quincey gave his Sorrows exactly their title.

The Graeae, three grey sisters, share a single eye and a single tooth; Perseus steals the eye in passage between them to learn the way to the Gorgons. Their myth makes sight a communal organ passed among women and stolen by the hero, an economy the film's ocular regime will reproduce (Chapter 7). The Gorgons themselves — Medusa, Stheno, Euryale — supply the petrifying face that Freud read as the terror of the mother's body ("Medusa's Head," 1922).

Hecate stands nearest to the film. Hesiod honors her above all other deities (*Theogony* 411–452); later cult made her *triformis*, three-bodied, goddess of crossroads, night, and witches, attended by howling dogs. In the Homeric Hymn to Demeter it is Hecate who hears Persephone's cry from her cave and who meets the grieving Demeter bearing torches. The Eleusinian triad of Demeter, Kore, and Hecate is the closest ancient analogue of a triad of mothers organized around a daughter's descent. Carl Kerényi and C. G. Jung, in their joint essays on the divine child and the divine maiden (1941), treated Demeter and Kore as one figure seen twice: every mother contains her daughter, every daughter her mother, and each woman extends backward into her mother and forward into her daughter. That identity across generations is what the film's ending will exploit.

Finally, De Quincey reminds us that "once even the Muses were but three." Pausanias records the original Muses of Helicon as Melete, Mneme, and Aoide — Practice, Memory, and Song (9.29). No triad could better describe the curriculum of a dance academy: rehearsal, the memory of choreography, and music.

3.3 Northern, Rhenish, and Shakespearean triads

The Norns of the *Völuspá* (st. 20) — Urðr, Verðandi, and Skuld, roughly what was, what is becoming, and what shall be — sit at the well beneath the world-tree, lay down laws, and choose the lives of the children of men. Their Anglo-Saxon cognate *wyrd* survives in Holinshed's gloss on the "weird sisters" who meet Macbeth, "the goddesses of destinie," and through Holinshed in Shakespeare's witches. The witches of *Macbeth* are the hinge between the classical Fates and the early-modern coven, and De Quincey's essay on that play's knocking (Chapter 1) is the hinge between De Quincey and Argento.

The most precise iconographic precedent, however, is Rhenish. Hundreds of votive stones from the Roman Rhineland of the second and third centuries honor triads of mother-goddesses, the *Matronae*, of whom the Matronae Aufaniae of Bonn are the best known. Their characteristic image shows three seated women: two older matrons in great round bonnets flanking a younger, bareheaded woman. A girl seated between two mothers is the iconographic type of *Suspiria*'s second act, in which Suzy is placed between Madame Blanc and Miss Tanner. Freiburg lies on the Upper Rhine; the Mothers came home.

3.4 Marian sorrows and the infernal counter-Trinity

The Mothers' Latin titles are Marian in form. *Mater* followed by a genitive is the grammar of the litanies — *Mater purissima*, *Mater castissima*, *Mater dolorosa* — and of the devotion to the Seven Sorrows of Mary, cultivated by the Servite Order founded in Florence in 1233 and sung in the *Stabat Mater* traditionally ascribed to Jacopone da Todi. De Quincey makes the borrowing explicit when he grants Our Lady of Tears the title "Madonna." *Mater Suspiriorum* sounds like a litany because it parodies one.

The Gospels supply the triad of women before the absent body. Three Marys stand by the cross (John 19:25), and in the earliest Gospel three women come to the tomb, find it empty, and flee in terror, saying nothing to anyone, "for they were afraid" (Mark 16:1–8). A triad of women, an invisible presence, terror, and silence: the Markan ending is the Christian prototype of the scene that closes *Suspiria*, where a woman confronts a body that cannot be seen.

Dante supplies the counter-Trinity. His Lucifer, frozen at the center of the earth, has three faces — red, yellowish-white, and black — and weeps from six eyes, tears dripping with bloody foam down three chins (*Inferno* XXXIV). The infernal anti-Trinity is a trinity of tears in three colors. At the walls of Dis the three Furies summon Medusa, and Virgil covers Dante's eyes (*Inferno* IX). Jung argued that the Christian Trinity lacked a fourth term — the feminine, or evil — and hailed the dogma of Mary's Assumption (1950) as a partial correction (1942/1948; 1952). Argento's Mothers are a trinity composed entirely of the excluded fourth: feminine and evil at once.

3.5 The modern mythography of the Mother

The Mothers' deepest stratum is not ancient but modern: the nineteenth- and twentieth-century invention of a prehistoric maternal order. Johann Jakob Bachofen, a jurist of Basel, a short distance up the Rhine from Freiburg, published *Das Mutterrecht* in 1861. He reconstructed a sequence from a chthonic, tellurian stage through a Demetrian matriarchy to an Apollonian order of fathers, and he read the *Oresteia* as the drama of father-right's victory. Engels absorbed Bachofen into *The Origin of the Family, Private Property and the State* (1884), calling the overthrow of mother-right "die weltgeschichtliche Niederlage des weiblichen Geschlechts," the world-historical defeat of the female sex. Jane Ellen Harrison (1903; 1912) recovered a pre-Olympian religion of Mother and Maiden beneath the Homeric pantheon. James George Frazer opened *The Golden Bough* (1890) at Nemi, in the Alban Hills, where the priest of Diana held office until slain by his successor. Charles Godfrey Leland's *Aradia* (1899) presented a purported gospel of Tuscan witches in which Diana sends her daughter Aradia to teach witchcraft to the oppressed as a weapon against their masters. Jules Michelet's *La Sorcière* (1862) had already made the witch a healer and rebel of the people; Margaret Murray (1921) made her the priestess of a surviving fertility cult; Robert Graves (1948) codified the Triple Goddess as maiden, mother, and crone; Erich Neumann (1955) split the archetypal Great Mother into Good and Terrible; and Marija Gimbutas (1974) located a goddess civilization in Neolithic Old Europe.

Ronald Hutton has shown that the maiden-mother-crone triad is largely a modern construction, assembled from Harrison and Graves rather than inherited from antiquity (1999). This does not weaken the Mothers; it defines them. A modern myth requires a fabricated antiquity, and the trilogy supplies one in the form of a book.

3.6 Varelli's cosmography

Inferno (1980) introduces *The Three Mothers*, an antiquarian volume by the alchemist-architect Varelli, who built three houses for the Mothers in Freiburg, Rome, and New York. The houses are the Mothers' bodies; to enter them is to enter the Mother. Varelli is a fictional Fulcanelli, the pseudonymous adept whose *Le Mystère des cathédrales* (1926) and *Les Demeures philosophales* (1930) read Gothic buildings as alchemical texts. His cosmography is also a geography of sorrow.

Freiburg lies on the Upper Rhine at the edge of the Black Forest, near the border triangle where Steiner built at Dornach, and the production reproduced the academy's façade from the city's late-Gothic Haus zum Walfisch. That house has a resonant tenant. Erasmus of Rotterdam, leaving Basel after the city turned Protestant, moved to Freiburg in April 1529 and lived in this house until 1531; in the same year he published his treatise on the early and liberal education of children, *De pueris statim ac liberaliter instituendis*. The façade of the witches' academy is the house in which the greatest humanist pedagogue lived in the year he published his pedagogy. This is a grade-three constellation, but it states the film's argument architecturally: the coven wears the face of humanist education. Rome is the Madonna's city, the capital of tears, of lament and the *Pietà*. New York is the metropolis of modernity, the darkness of capital and electricity. One design-historical account notes

that the set designer Giuseppe Bassan placed the silhouette of the Empire State Building in the academy's bathroom windows, so that the next Mother's city is already glimpsed from the first.

Freiburg also burned its witches. On 24 March 1599 the city beheaded three women convicted of witchcraft — Catharina Stadellmenin, Anna Wolffartin, and Margaretha Mößmerin — and burned their bodies outside the walls, among others executed in its persecutions around 1600. A plaque on the Martinstor, the medieval city gate a short walk from the Haus zum Walfisch, now honors them on behalf of all the women who fell victim to the witch-craze. The coven of *Suspiria* burns, at the end, in that city. The film restages Freiburg's pyres with the roles reversed: the "witches" are the persecutors, and the fire consumes their institution rather than their victims. That reversal is the historical form of the ambivalence Chapter 9 examines.

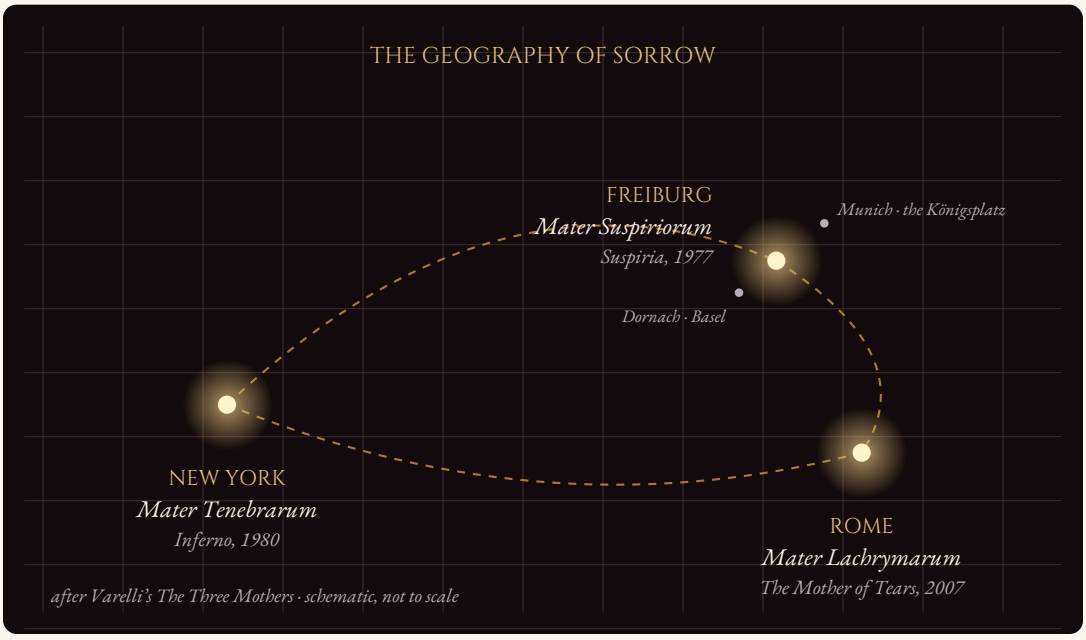


FIGURE 4 *The geography of sorrow: Varelli's three houses, with the places the argument sets around Freiburg.*

3.7 Three states of sorrow, and the fourth

Read together, De Quincey's portraits and Argento's trilogy yield a coherent system. Each Mother is a mode of grief with its own emblem, gait, element, and city.

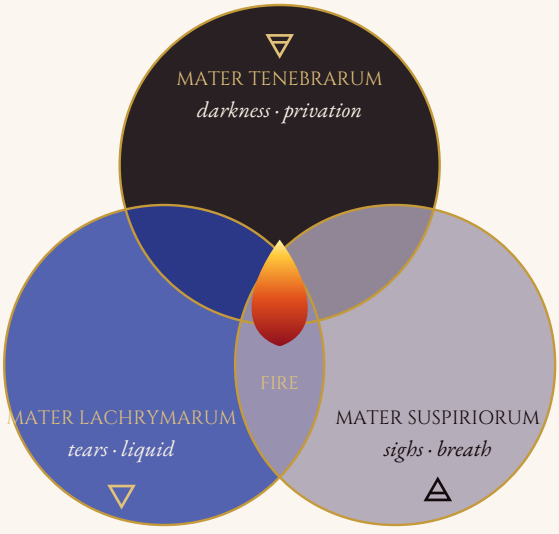
	MATER LACHRYMARUM *Our Lady of Tears*	MATER SUSPIRIORUM *Our Lady of Sighs*	MATER TENEBRARUM *Our Lady of Darkness*
DE QUINCEY'S EMBLEM	Diadem; "keys more than papal"	"Dilapidated turban"; a key she "needs little"	Turreted like Cybele; "treble veil of crape"; no key
GAIT	"Tragic grace"	"Creeps timidly and stealthily"	"Tiger's leaps"

	MATER LACHRYMARUM *Our Lady of Tears*	MATER SUSPIRIORUM *Our Lady of Sighs*	MATER TENEBRARUM *Our Lady of Darkness*
STATE OF SORROW	Liquid: sorrow expressed outward	Aerial: sorrow suppressed into breath	Privative: sorrow as the absence of light
VARELLI'S HOUSE	Rome	Freiburg	New York
MYTHIC ANALOGUES	Demeter, Rachel, the Mater Dolorosa	Persephone and the shades; the feminine Spirit	Hecate, Nyx, Cybele
END IN THE TRILOGY	Dies amid fire and collapse (*The Mother of Tears*, 2007)	Pierced through the neck; the academy burns (*Suspiria*, 1977)	The house burns (*Inferno*, 1980)

Tears, sighs, and darkness are grief's three phase-states: the liquid, sorrow expressed and flowing outward; the aerial, sorrow suppressed and held as breath; the privative, sorrow become the absence of light itself. Water, air, and night-earth are present. Fire is missing — and fire is the element in which each Mother's house perishes. Empedocles' four roots are completed only in the Mothers' destruction.

The alchemical tradition has a formula for this structure. The axiom attributed to Maria Prophetissa, the woman alchemist of late antiquity, which Jung made a key to his psychology, reads: one becomes two, two becomes three, and out of the third comes the one as the fourth. The fourth that completes the triad of Mothers is not a fourth Mother. It is the daughter who passes through the fire. That is the structural basis of Chapter 10.

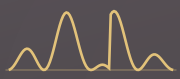
ONE BECOMES TWO, TWO BECOMES THREE,



AND OUT OF THE THIRD COMES THE ONE AS THE FOURTH

— the axiom of Maria Prophetissa

FIGURE 5 *Three states of sorrow and the fourth: tears, sighs and darkness meet in fire, the element of the daughter, after the axiom attributed to Maria Prophetissa.*



PART TWO · THE MOTHERS

CHAPTER

IV

Suspirium

A Pneumatology of the Sigh

She weeps not. She groans not. But she sighs inaudibly at intervals.

DE QUINCEY · "LEVANA"

The sovereign of *Suspiria* is a breath: she is twice identified by her respiration and never by her face, she governs through an acoustic regime of whispers and panting voices, she dies by a wound to the organ of breathing, and her coven perishes when her breath stops — so that the film's metaphysics is best described as an infernal counter-pneumatology, a theology of the Spirit turned feminine, sovereign, and unholy.

4.1 The philology of the sigh

Suspirium derives from *suspirare*, *sub* plus *spirare*: to breathe from beneath, to draw breath up from below. The family is theological from the start. *Spiritus* comes from the same verb; *anima* is cognate with the Greek *anemos*, wind; *psychē* is related to *psychein*, to breathe or blow; *pneuma* derives from *pnein*, to breathe; the Hebrew *ruach* means wind, breath, and spirit at once, and is usually grammatically feminine. In Genesis 2:7 God breathes into the nostrils of the clay the *nishmat chayyim*, the breath of life. De Quincey's Levana begins her office at the moment when the infant "tasted for the first time the atmosphere of our troubled planet." Birth is the first breath; formation begins as respiration.

The sigh occupies a unique place in this lexicon. It is breath that has become sign: a deep intake and a prolonged release that signify without words. It is involuntary and expressive at once, a reflex and a message, and it stands therefore exactly at the border between the body and language. That is why it can serve as the medium of a sovereign who, in De Quincey's phrase, "disdain[s] the infirmities of language."

4.2 The feminine Spirit

A minority tradition within Christianity imagined the Spirit as a mother. A fragment of the lost Gospel of the Hebrews, quoted by Origen and Jerome, has Jesus speak of "my mother, the Holy Spirit," who carried him by a single hair to Mount Tabor. Early Syriac Christianity, whose word for spirit was grammatically feminine, could address the Spirit as mother; in the nineteenth of the Odes of Solomon the Spirit opens her bosom and mingles the milk of the Father's two breasts. The Wisdom of Proverbs, *Ḥokhmah*, is present at creation "rejoicing always before him" (8:30); the Hebrew participle means playing or sporting, and Wisdom has often been read as a cosmic player, even a dancer, before God.

Valentinian Gnosticism took the decisive step. In the myth Irenaeus reports (*Adversus haereses* I. 4.1–2), the fallen Sophia suffers grief, fear, and perplexity, and her passions become the substance of the world: from her tears all moist substance, from her laughter all that is luminous, from her grief and terror the corporeal elements. Here is the ultimate source-myth of the Mothers of Sorrow. The world is not merely visited by a mother's grief; it is made of it. The Valentinian cosmogony supplies what De Quincey's Christian frame lacked — a feminine sorrow that is not only suffered but generative, sorrow as matter — and it holds in reserve a detail to which Chapter 10 returns: from the Mother's laughter came light.

4.3 Romans 8 and the inaudible sigh

The Pauline text is the hinge. "The whole creation groaneth and travaileth in pain together until now" (Romans 8:22): the Greek *systenazei kai synōdinei* means that creation groans together and suffers birth-pangs together. Four verses later, "the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us with groanings which cannot be uttered" (8:26): *stenagmois alalētois*, in the Vulgate *gemitibus inenarrabilibus*. Two features matter. The cosmic groan is maternal, the groan of labor. And the Spirit's speech is a sigh beneath language, inaudible because it precedes words.

De Quincey's Mater Suspiriorum "sighs inaudibly at intervals." The inaudibility is Pauline, but the intercession has been drained away: what remains is "the meekness that belongs to the hopeless." Argento makes a third turn. The sigh becomes audible — hoarse, labored, the respiration of an ancient body — and it becomes sovereign. The trajectory from Paul through De Quincey to Argento runs from intercession to hopelessness to rule. The Spirit that once groaned on behalf of creation now governs it. This is the precise sense in which the film's metaphysics is a counter-pneumatology: it keeps the feminine Spirit of the minority tradition, keeps the inaudible sigh of Romans, and in-

verts their direction, so that breath no longer rises toward God in prayer but descends upon bodies as command.

4.4 The sleeping breath

The film identifies its sovereign twice, and both times by breath. In the first instance, maggots rain from the ceilings of the students' rooms, and the girls are moved to sleep in a dance studio behind sheets hung around its walls. In the night a woman enters, hidden by the curtain, and Sara, terrified by her hoarse and labored breathing, recognizes her as the headmistress, who is supposed to be away. In the second, at the climax, Suzy finds Markos asleep in her bedroom and recognizes her by the same labored breathing. The Mother is never identified by an icon. She is identified by an index, in Charles Sanders Peirce's sense: a sign bound to its object by physical connection, as smoke is to fire and breath to a living body. For most of the film Markos exists only indexically.

De Quincey had written of the Sorrow of Sighs: "Murmur she may, but it is in her sleep." Argento's Markos is a sleeping sovereign, and the figure has a German pedigree: the emperor Barbarossa asleep beneath the Kyffhäuser, awaiting his return; Brünnhilde asleep on her rock inside a ring of fire in Wagner's *Siegfried*; Snow White asleep in glass. The academy is, in this light, the Mother's dream. Gilles Deleuze, in his 1987 lecture on the creative act, warned that whoever is caught in another's dream is lost. The students live inside the sleep of the Mother, and the house runs on her respiration. Suzy wakes her by shattering a glass peacock, and the significance of that instrument — a bird whose tail bears the eyes of the hundred-eyed Argus — is the subject of Chapter 7.

4.5 The acousmatic Mother

Michel Chion's *La Voix au cinéma* (1982) defined the *acousmêtre* as a voice whose source is not seen, and attributed to it four powers: ubiquity, panopticism, omniscience, and omnipotence. His canonical cases are the mother in *Psycho*, Dr. Mabuse speaking from behind a curtain in Lang's *Testament* (1933), and the Wizard of Oz. The acousmêtre loses its powers at the moment of *de-acousmatization*, when the body that produces the voice is shown; embodied, it becomes mortal.

Chion's theory explains the climax of *Suspiria* with uncanny precision. Woken, Markos makes herself invisible and taunts Suzy in a disembodied voice, then reanimates Sara's corpse against her. She is an acousmêtre at the height of its powers. Lightning reveals her silhouette, and in that instant Suzy can kill her. The matricide is a de-acousmatization. The trilogy's second film confirms the pattern from another angle: in *Inferno* the architect of the Mothers' houses, Varelli, survives as a wheelchair-bound scholar who speaks through an electronic voice box. The servant of the Mothers speaks through a prosthesis; the voice of the Mothers' architecture is already a machine. When he attacks the hero, the cord of that apparatus catches around his neck and chokes him: in the second film, too, a death comes at the throat, by the very instrument of voice. The last film of the trilogy makes even the good mother an acousmêtre. In The Mother of Tears, Nicolodi's Elisa survives only as a disembodied voice that guides her daughter and teaches her to make herself invisible — the Mother of

Sighs' own power, passed down the matrilineal line from the co-author of the first film to her real daughter.

4.6 Goblin's pneumatic score, and the dubbed voice

The production record states that Goblin composed most of the score in collaboration with Argento and that, like Morricone's scores for Leone, it existed before the film was shot; it was reportedly played on set. Its textures are respiratory: a nursery ostinato on celesta, bouzouki, tabla, synthesizer, and voices that whisper, gasp, pant, and hiss the word "witch." The score is literally an atmosphere — *atmos*, vapor, plus *sphaira* — an envelope of breath in which bodies move. In a dance academy music commands bodies; in *Suspiria* the music that commands them is the Mother's respiration rendered audible. De Quincey had heard the Sorrows' mysteries "deciphered by harp and timbrel, by dulcimer and organ"; the bouzouki is the dulcimer's modern kin.

The treatment of voice completes the pneumatic design. Nearly all the dialogue was dubbed in post-production, as Italian practice then required, so that the characters speak with breath supplied later, by other mouths, in another room. The production record notes a single exception: the scene at the academy after the first murder, in which the police investigate, preserves the dialogue recorded on set. The voice of the law is the only native voice in the film; every other voice is re-breathed in the studio. In the Italian version the narration that frames the tale is spoken by Argento himself, so that a paternal voice-over encloses a house governed by a maternal breath.

Hoberman's claim that the film makes sense only to the eye is therefore precisely wrong. Its decisive acts of knowledge are aural. Pat's three words reach Suzy torn by the wind of the storm. Sara proves that the teachers do not leave the building at night by counting their footsteps, and Suzy finds the coven by following those footsteps. The Mother is recognized by her breathing. The *giallo*, in Argento's *L'uccello dalle piume di cristallo* (1970) and *Profondo rosso* (1975), had founded its epistemology on a misperceived image — a scene glimpsed through glass, a face missed in a mirror. *Suspiria* converts that epistemology of the eye into an epistemology of the ear.

4.7 The throat, and pneumatography

The film's killings converge on the organ of breath. Pat is stabbed and then hanged by a noose through a skylight. Daniel's dog tears out his throat. Sara, trapped in a pit of razor wire, has her throat cut. Markos is impaled through the neck. When she dies, the coven perishes without the power that sustained it. Each death stops a breath; the final death stops the breath on which all the others depended. *Suspiria* is anti-pneumatic in its violence and pneumatic in its metaphysics: the Mother of Sighs kills by stopping breath and is killed in the same way.

The term for this method comes from the history of spiritualism, and its history is itself pneumatic. In 1857 Baron Ludwig von Güldenstubbé, an Estonian-born spiritualist in Paris, published a *Pneumatologie positive et expérimentale*, claiming that spirits had written directly, without any human hand, on blank sheets he left in sealed boxes and at tombs and statues. In January 1858 Allan Kardec, crediting Güldenstubbé as the first in Europe to bring the phenomenon forward, proposed

the name *pneumatography* for such direct writing — from *pneuma*, which he glossed as air, breath, wind, and spirit — and *pneumatophony* for voices and sounds that spirits produce directly, without a medium. Repurposed, the pair names the film's method. *Suspiria*'s decisive inscriptions are made by breath: words carried by wind, steps counted in the dark, a sleeping sigh, a whispered score, voices breathed into the image after the fact. Its sounds are pneumatophonic: voices without bodies, breaths without faces. And the surface on which Güldenstubbé awaited the spirits' writing, a blank sheet, returns as the blank film that received the film's colors (Chapter 5) and as the blank dream screen of the psychoanalysts (Chapter 8). Friedrich Kittler's *Aufschreibesysteme 1800/1900* (1985) gives this method a history. Around 1800, Kittler argues, the mother's voice — the "Mother's Mouth" — anchored the child's entry into language and the whole system of *Bildung*; around 1900, phonograph and film began to record voice and breath directly, and technical media displaced the mother as the source of discourse. A Mother of Sighs who founds her academy in 1895 stands exactly at that hinge: a maternal voice in the process of becoming an apparatus. Part Three follows that apparatus into color, dance, sight, and the cinema itself.



FIGURE 6 *A sigh, interrupted: each killing in the film, and Varelli's in Inferno, stops a breath at the throat; the last breath released is the smile.*

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PART THREE · THE APPARATUS

CHAPTER

V

Heraldries Painted on Darkness

Imbibition, Matrices, and the Sufferings of Light

...heraldries painted on darkness, and hieroglyphics written on the tablets of the brain.

DE QUINCEY · "LEVANA"

Color in *Suspiria* is not decoration laid over a story but the visible form of its subject: it is what Goethe called the suffering of light, it was physically produced by three matrices that rehearse the three Mothers, and it acts on the spectator as De Quincey's opium acted on him — as a *pharmakon* that wakes and sedates at once.

5.1 De Quincey's palette

The source had already chosen the colors. De Quincey's Fates weave "with colours sad in part, sometimes angry with tragic crimson and black"; his Sorrows communicate through "heraldries painted on darkness" and trace their plots "on the mirrors of darkness." Heraldry is color made into a code of identity and lineage — gules, azure, vert, sable — displayed against a field. To paint heraldries on darkness is to project a coded color onto a black ground, which is a fair description of a cinema screen in a darkened room and an exact description of *Suspiria*'s night interiors, in which saturated fields of red, blue, and green are thrown against blackness. The film's palette is a heraldry of the Mothers: the color of their house, their lineage, and their claim.

5.2 Goethe: the deeds and sufferings of light

Goethe opens the *Farbenlehre* (1810) with a definition that this dissertation takes as a key: "Die Farben sind Taten des Lichts, Taten und Leiden" — colors are the deeds of light, its deeds and its sufferings. Against Newton's analysis of white light into its spectral components, Goethe proposed that color arises at the boundary of light and darkness, through a turbid medium (*das Trübe*). Light seen through a turbid medium yellows; darkness seen through an illuminated turbid medium blues. Yellow and blue form the poles of a system that, through *Steigerung* — intensification — rises at both ends toward red, culminating in *Purpur*, the highest color, where the intensified poles meet. In the same preface Goethe lists the polarities through which nature speaks to the eye — a doing and a suffering, an advancing and a holding-back, a violent and a moderating, "ein Männliches, ein Weibliches," a masculine and a feminine — so that, in the order of his pairs, suffering falls on the same side as the feminine.

The sixth division of the didactic part, on the "sensory-moral effect" of color, reads like a commentary on the film. Goethe's *Purpur* gives, in Goethe's words, "einen Eindruck sowohl von Ernst und Würde als von Huld und Anmut," an impression of gravity and dignity as well as of grace and charm, the first in its dark, condensed state, the second in its light, diluted one. Through a purple glass, he adds, a well-lit landscape appears "in furchtbarem Lichte," in a terrible light: such must be the color spread over heaven and earth "am Tage des Gerichts," on the Day of Judgment (§ 798). The word for grace here is *Anmut*, the term Schiller had made the name of grace in movement (Chapter 6). Blue, in its highest purity, is "gleichsam ein reizendes Nichts," as it were a charming nothing, and there is in its aspect "etwas Widersprechendes von Reiz und Ruhe," something contradictory of stimulation and repose; and "wie wir einen angenehmen Gegenstand, der vor uns flieht, gern verfolgen, so sehen wir das Blaue gern an, nicht weil es auf uns dringt, sondern weil es uns nach sich zieht" — as we gladly pursue a pleasing object that flees from us, so we love to look at blue, not because it presses on us but because it draws us after it. The contradiction of stimulation and repose is already the structure of the pharmakon examined in section 5.7. That is the dramaturgy of the blue iris on Madame Blanc's wall: a color that recedes and, receding, draws the heroine after it into the secret passage. The flower has its own Romantic genealogy. Novalis's *Heinrich von Ofterdingen* (1802) made the blue flower the emblem of German Romantic longing, *Sehnsucht*, for the infinite. In *Suspiria* the emblem of longing has become a latch, and the infinite it opens onto is the Mother's chamber.

Goethe's formula is the principle of what I call the film's **chromatic Passion**. If color is light's suffering, then a film saturated in color is a film in which light suffers visibly, and the Sorrows, which De Quincey said speak only in signs, have found their proper medium. Red in *Suspiria* is not primarily the color of blood, though blood is red; it is *Purpur*, the culminating color, the royal and sacrificial color of the robe placed on Christ in the Passion (John 19:2), the color of the academy's façade and of its inner flesh. The academy is a body suffering light, and its red is Goethe's judgment-light: a landscape seen through purple glass, a world already under sentence.

GOETHE'S CIRCLE, READ FOR SUSPIRIA

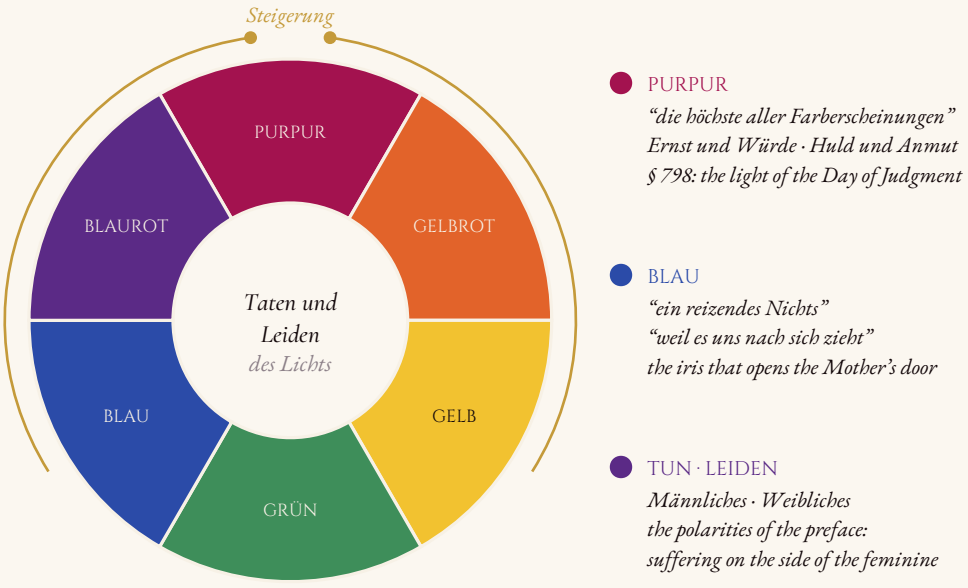


FIGURE 7 *Goethe's colour circle read for Suspiria: Purpur at the summit, blue receding and drawing the eye after it, and the polarities of the preface.*

5.3 The grammar of color

Goethe's polemic against Newton had a philosophical afterlife. Schopenhauer's *On Vision and Colors* (1816) relocated color in the qualitative activity of the retina. Wittgenstein's *Remarks on Colour*, published in 1977, returned to Goethe in order to ask not what color is but how color concepts function, and dwelt on puzzles such as why something can be transparent and green but not transparent and white. The film answers Wittgenstein's puzzle with its instruments of death. Its lethal objects are transparent and colored: the stained-glass skylight through which Pat is hanged, the falling shard that kills Sonia, the glass quill that kills Markos. White, by contrast, is opaque and receptive: the sheets behind which the girls sleep and the Mother breathes, the name of the deputy headmistress, and, as the next sections show, the industrial name of the film on which the color was printed. In *Suspiria* transparency wounds and whiteness receives.

5.4 Kandinsky and the synesthetic stage

In Munich, where *Suspiria*'s exteriors of the airport and the Königsplatz were shot, Wassily Kandinsky wrote *Über das Geistige in der Kunst* (dated 1912) under theosophical and anthroposophical influence. Colors, he argued, are vibrations of the soul governed by "inner necessity"; each has an inner sound, and he correlated yellow with the brass and deepening blues with the descending registers of

flute, cello, double bass, and organ. In the *Blaue Reiter* almanac (1912) he published *Der gelbe Klang*, *The Yellow Sound*, a stage composition of colored light, music, and movement without plot. Alexander Scriabin's *Prometheus: The Poem of Fire* (1910) wrote a part for a color organ. The utopia of synesthetic art — color heard, sound seen, bodies moved by both — is the program of a film whose score preceded its images and whose story, as its critics complained, periodically stops. *Suspiria* is a cinematic *Der rote Klang*: a stage composition in which narrative is subordinated to the correspondence of color, sound, and moving bodies.

Cinema had pursued this utopia before. In the color sequence of Eisenstein's *Ivan the Terrible, Part II* (shot 1945–1946, released 1958), the tsar's guard dances a frenzied bacchanal in red and gold before a murder in a cathedral, and Eisenstein's writings on color argued that color must be determined by theme rather than by nature. Mario Bava's *Sei donne per l'assassino* (1964) lit a fashion house, an institution of women, in saturated gels while its models were murdered one by one; it is the direct generic ancestor of Argento's palette. Powell and Pressburger's *Black Narcissus* (1947) set a community of nuns in a former Himalayan palace and ended when Sister Ruth, maddened by desire and jealousy, tries to push her superior from the bell tower and falls to her own death; their *The Red Shoes* (1948) adapted Andersen's tale — published, like *Suspiria de Profundis*, in 1845 — of a girl compelled to dance until her feet are cut off. Ingmar Bergman's *Cries and Whispers* (1972) enclosed three sisters and a maid in blood-red rooms while one sister dies in labored breaths; Bergman reportedly explained that he had always imagined the interior of the soul as red. Each is an institution or household of women rendered in saturated color. *Suspiria* inherits the form and makes it explicit.

5.5 Imbibition: the industrial matrices

The production record specifies how the color was made. Luciano Tovoli was engaged on the strength of color tests that matched Argento's vision, itself modelled on Disney's *Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs* (1937); Argento said they wanted Technicolor's lack of subdued shades, its quality of flat cut-out cartoon color. The film was shot with anamorphic lenses, its design built on primary colors, especially red, and its release prints made by Technicolor's dye-imbibition process — the process used for *The Wizard of Oz* and *Gone with the Wind* in 1939, more vivid than emulsion-based prints — on what the record describes as the last remaining machine in Rome.

The process deserves exact description, because its structure is the film's. From the camera negative three separation records are made, one each for red, green, and blue light. From each record a relief image is formed in hardened gelatin: a *matrix*. Each matrix is soaked in a dye complementary to its record — cyan, magenta, or yellow — and, like a printing plate, transfers its dye in register onto a receiving film coated with mordanted gelatin, which the industry called the **blank**. The dye is absorbed — *imbibed* — and the finished image consists of dyes alone, not of silver. *Suspiria*'s color is therefore the product of three matrices, each charged with one color, laid successively onto a blank that receives them. Its print contains no image in silver — *argento* — at all.

These are the industry's own terms. Technicolor's annual report of 1955 describes the process as the transfer of dye from special positive stocks called matrices to another stock called a "release print blank," which, after receiving its soundtrack, becomes the print shipped to the world's theatres; the

blank was essentially a black-and-white film treated with mordants to hold the dyes. In a print of this period, whatever silver the film carried lay in its optical soundtrack, not in its image. The onomastic paradox therefore sharpens: on a print whose pictures contain no silver, the only *argento* belongs to the sound — to the voices, the score, and the breath.

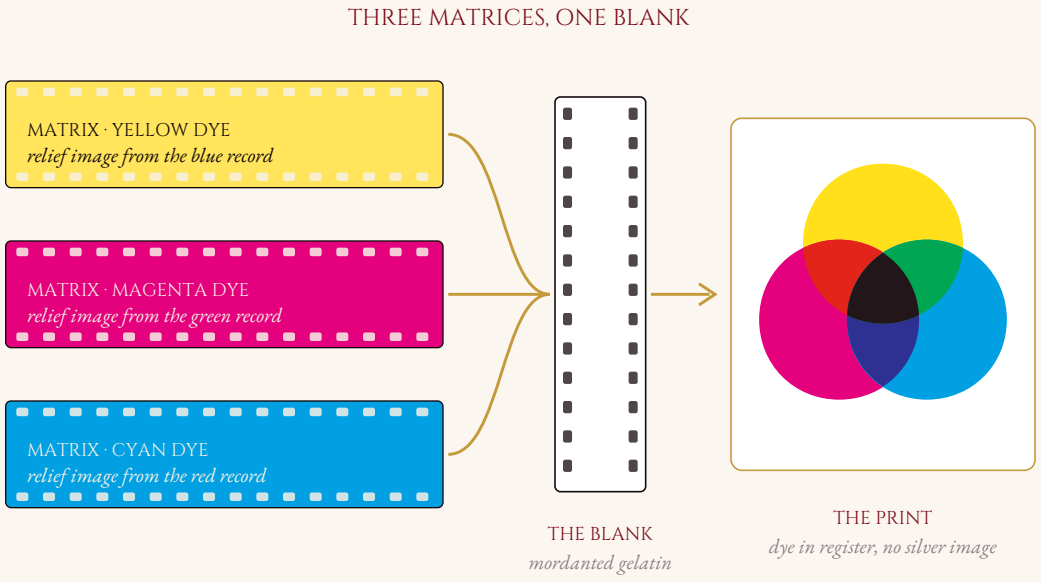


FIGURE 8 *Three matrices, one blank: in Technicolor's dye-imbibition process three dyed relief matrices transfer their colours in register onto a receiving blank.*

5.6 Matrical theory: matrix, matricula, chora

Matrix is formed from *mater*. In Latin it meant a breeding female and the womb; later, a source or register. Its diminutive, the Late Latin *matricula*, a public register, gives modern European languages *matriculation*: the inscription of a student's name in the roll of a school. The words name the film's argument with almost embarrassing precision. Suzy *matriculates* at the academy: she is inscribed in the Mother's register. The film that records her matriculation was printed from three *matrices*: its images were born of three mother-forms, each charged with one color. And the surface that received them was a *blank* — the industrial cognate of *Blanc*, the name of the woman who receives Suzy into the house. This is a grade-two homology in the strict sense defined in the Introduction, recurring at the material, narrative, and mythic levels at once: three Sorrows, three Mothers, three matrices; a white receiving surface, a white-named matron, a girl to be impressed. The spectator's retina is the last blank in the series.

The philosophical prototype of this structure is Plato's *chōra*. In the *Timaeus* the "third kind," between the intelligible forms and their sensible copies, is the receptacle (*hypodochē*) and "nurse of all becoming" (49a). Plato likens the receiving principle to a mother, the source of the forms to a father,

and what arises between them to a child (50d). He calls the receptacle an *ekmageion*, a molding stuff on which impressions are stamped, often translated *matrix* (50c), and compares it to the odorless base perfumers prepare to receive scents (50e). Julia Kristeva's *Révolution du langage poétique* (1974) reread the *chora* as a pre-symbolic, rhythmic, pulsional space bound to the maternal body; Derrida's *Khôra* (1993) examined its refusal to be either form or matter. The academy is a *chora* in Kristeva's sense: a rhythmic, maternal receptacle, organized by music and pulse, in which forms — dancers — are impressed.

Goethe gave the maternal receptacle its most theatrical image. In the second part of *Faust* (1832), Faust must descend to *die Mütter*, the Mothers, who dwell beyond space and time, "umschwebt von Bildern aller Kreatur" — hovered round by images of every creature — presiding over "Gestaltung, Umgestaltung, / Des ewigen Sinnes ewige Unterhaltung," formation and transformation, the eternal mind's eternal recreation. Goethe's Mothers are the archive and matrix of all images. To read Argento's Mothers through Goethe's, as the next chapters do, is to read them as the source from which images are born — and, therefore, as an allegory of the cinema.

5.7 The chromatic Passion and the pharmakon

Nietzsche wrote in *The Birth of Tragedy* (1872) that "nur als ästhetisches Phänomen ist das Dasein und die Welt ewig gerechtfertigt" — only as an aesthetic phenomenon are existence and the world eternally justified. That is the formula of an aesthetic theodicy, and De Quincey's essay on murder as a fine art was its satirical prototype. *Suspiria*'s chromatic Passion is tempted by it: the suffering of light is so beautiful that it seems to justify itself. Susan Sontag's "Fascinating Fascism" (1975) named the political danger of such beauty, the seduction of a spectacle that turns bodies into ornament under a hypnotic will (Chapter 9).

The film's answer is not to renounce the seduction but to show its mechanism. Derrida's "La pharmacie de Platon" (1968) recovered the double sense of the Greek *pharmakon*, at once remedy and poison. De Quincey's apostrophe to "just, subtle, and mighty opium" celebrated the drug that gave him his visions and his torments. *Suspiria* has its own *pharmakon*: the wine Suzy is given after her collapse, which sedates her into compliance until she refuses it. Color in the film is a *pharmakon* of the same kind. It numbs, as Technicolor's cartoon brilliance lulls the eye into the nursery; and it wakes, because the same colored transparencies are the instruments that cut. The print itself was made by imbibition, the absorption of dye into gelatin. The heroine is subdued by imbibition, the absorption of a drugged wine. The spectator, too, imbibes. Augustine, describing his friend Alypius at the gladiatorial games, wrote that at the sight of blood he drank in the savagery (*immanitatem ebibit*) and absorbed the frenzy without knowing it (*Confessions* VI.8). Chapter 7 returns to that drinking eye.

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PART THREE · THE APPARATUS

CHAPTER

VI

Grace and the Marionette

Dance, Discipline, and the Anti-Bildung

They wheeled in mazes; I spelled the steps.

DE QUINCEY · "LEVANA"

The Tanz Akademie is an institution of aesthetic education whose promise — grace, freedom, the harmonious formation of the person — is Schiller's, and whose practice — sedation, surveillance, the reduction of dancers to puppets — is Kleist's nightmare; Suzy's curriculum inverts the *Bildungsroman* by ending not in her reconciliation with the institution but in its destruction.

6.1 The academy as total institution

Erving Goffman's *Asylums* (1961) defined the "total institution" — asylum, prison, barracks, convent, boarding school — as a place of residence and work where a large number of like-situated individuals, cut off from the wider society, lead an enclosed, formally administered round of life; its first operation on the inmate is the "mortification of the self." Michel Foucault's *Surveiller et punir* (1975) described the disciplinary techniques of such institutions: the partitioning of space, the timetable, *dressage* — the training of bodies to precise gestures — hierarchical observation, and the examination. The Tanz Akademie is a total institution in both senses. It houses its students, feeds them, prescribes for them through its physician, controls their sleep, assigns them rooms and moves them at will. Its techniques of observation are constant: the matron and the boy who watch Suzy in

the corridor; the eyes at the window; the intercom that admits or refuses. And its central lie is a fact about the timetable: the teachers claim to leave the building each night, and Sara proves, by counting their footsteps, that they go inward instead.

The disciplinary institution reveals its other face when it empties. On the night of the climax the whole school has left to see the Bolshoi Ballet: the academy exports its population to a performance of the art it teaches, so that the ritual for which the art is a mask can proceed in private. The institution's visible purpose and its occult purpose are not two activities but one apparatus seen from two sides.

6.2 Grace: Schiller and Kleist

The aesthetic education that the academy advertises is Schiller's. In "Über Anmut und Würde" (1793) grace, *Anmut*, is the beauty of form under the influence of freedom, the beauty of movement in which the will shows itself without constraint. In the *Letters on the Aesthetic Education of Man* (1795), the play drive reconciles the sensuous drive and the formal drive, and the famous fifteenth letter declares that "der Mensch spielt nur, wo er in voller Bedeutung des Worts Mensch ist, und er ist nur da ganz Mensch, wo er spielt" — man plays only when he is human in the full sense of the word, and he is fully human only when he plays. Dance is the purest instance of that play: the body moving freely under self-given form.

Kleist's "Über das Marionettentheater" (1810) is the dark answer, and *Suspiria* stages it. The narrator meets Herr C., the principal dancer of the opera, watching marionettes in a public square, and learns why he admires them. The puppet's soul, its *vis motrix*, sits exactly at its center of gravity, and so it is incapable of affectation, which arises whenever the soul is located anywhere other than in the center of a movement. Consciousness spoils grace. Grace appears most purely, Herr C. concludes, in the body that has either no consciousness at all or an infinite one: "in dem Gliedermann, oder in dem Gott" — in the jointed puppet or in the god. Return to innocence would require eating a second time from the tree of knowledge; that, he says, is the last chapter in the history of the world.

The academy pursues the first path. Its pedagogy aims at the puppet: the hex in the corridor, after which Suzy collapses in class like a marionette whose strings have been cut; the wine that sedates her; the reanimation of Sara's corpse, which the Mother moves from a distance as a puppeteer moves a doll, the soul relocated wholly outside the body. Suzy takes the second path. She stops drinking the wine, recovers consciousness, follows the counted footsteps, remembers Pat's words, and reads the iris. Her grace in the final sequence is that of infinite consciousness, the god's: she knows where the invisible Mother is, and kills her. The film thus dramatizes Kleist's alternative as a struggle. Either the institution makes the girl a puppet, or the girl, by knowing too much, becomes the god who ends the institution — a second eating from the tree of knowledge, and, for the academy, the last chapter of its history.

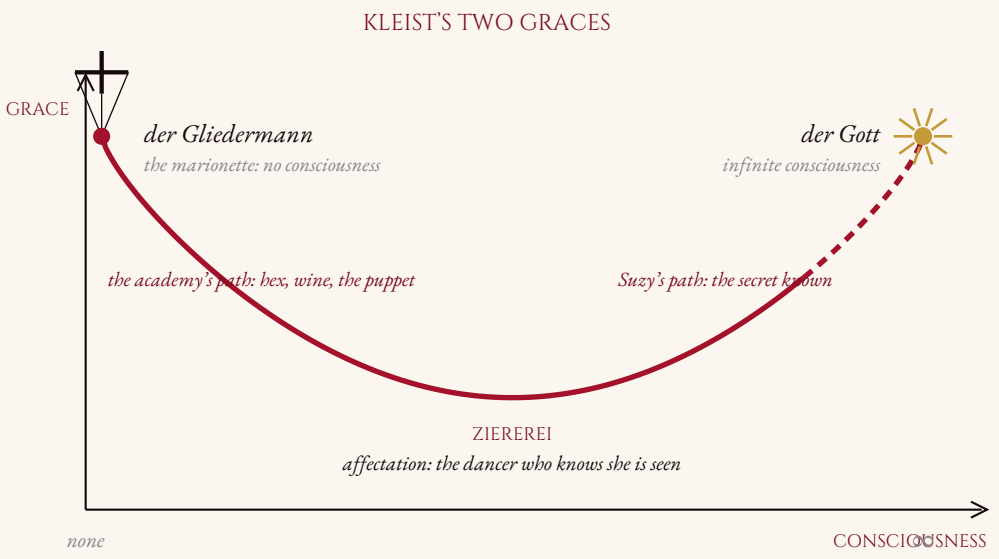


FIGURE 9 *Kleist's two graces: grace is greatest where consciousness is absent or infinite; between them lies affectation. The academy pursues the first path, Suzy the second.*

6.3 Automata: Hoffmann, Coppélia, Collodi

The girl as automaton has a literary history that runs through the ballet repertory itself. In E. T. A. Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann" (1816), Nathanael falls in love with Olympia, a mechanical doll who dances with uncanny, rigid exactness and sings with glassy perfection; his infatuation is induced by a spyglass bought from the sinister optician Coppola, a lens that enchants. Freud built "The Uncanny" (1919) on this tale and its threat to the eyes. Léo Delibes's *Coppélia* (1870) turned Hoffmann's automaton into one of the canonical ballets, in which the heroine Swanilda impersonates the doll in the workshop of the doll-maker Coppélius. Offenbach's *Les Contes d'Hoffmann* (1881) set Olympia beside Antonia, the singer for whom singing is death. Collodi's Pinocchio (Chapter 2), finally, is the marionette as pupil, the puppet whose education is the condition of becoming human.

The three texts mark the three faces of the animated puppet in European fiction: grace (Kleist), the uncanny (Hoffmann), and pedagogy (Collodi). *Suspiria*'s academy unites them. It is a school that teaches grace, its students are uncanny dolls in the Mother's hands, and its pedagogy is the conversion of girls into marionettes — a conversion that succeeds with Sara's corpse and fails with Suzy.

6.4 The Romantic ballet's covens

The repertory that a classical academy teaches is itself a mythology of supernatural women, and *Suspiria*'s coven is the Romantic ballet's unconscious. In *La Sylphide* (Paris, 1832), created by Filippo Taglioni for his daughter Marie, a witch, Madge, takes revenge on the hero by giving him a poisoned scarf that kills the sylph he loves. In *Giselle* (Paris, 1841), whose libretto by Théophile Gautier and

Vernoy de Saint-Georges was inspired by Heinrich Heine's account of the Wilis, the second act takes place at night in a German forest among the Wilis — the ghosts of brides who died before their weddings — who, under their queen Myrtha, compel any man they find to dance until he dies. In the definitive Petipa–Ivanov *Swan Lake* (St. Petersburg, 1895), maidens enchanted by a sorcerer are swans by day and women by night, and the heroine is doubled by her black counterpart. The second acts of *Giselle* and *Swan Lake* are the great *ballets blancs*, scenes of women in white under moonlight.

Madame Blanc presides over the *ballet blanc*. The academy rehearses, in its curriculum, the very sisterhoods it embodies in secret: dead maidens who kill men by dancing, a queen who commands them, a witch who poisons. Its men fare accordingly: Daniel, the accompanist, is torn apart, and Mark, the one male student we meet, simply drops out of the story. Hans Christian Andersen's "The Red Shoes," published in 1845 — the year of *Suspiria de Profundis* — had already made dance a curse: a girl compelled to dance until an executioner cuts off her feet.

The repertory also had a material history, which the first version of this chapter described too delicately. The Paris Opéra recruited its *petits rats*, its child pupils, largely from poor families, and from the 1830s it gave its wealthy male season subscribers, the *abonnés* — prominent among them members of the Jockey Club — access to the backstage *foyer de la danse*, where they could approach the dancers, adolescents among them. Sexual relationships with these patrons, frequently negotiated by the girls' own mothers, who depended on the income, were an open part of the institution's economy until the practice was curtailed between the wars; contemporaries described the foyer as a marketplace, and Ludovic Halévy satirized the brokering mother in his Cardinal stories (collected 1883), which Degas illustrated. Degas's model for *Little Dancer Aged Fourteen*, Marie van Goethem, was born in 1865 to an impoverished Belgian family and was about fourteen when she posed. When the wax figure was exhibited in 1881, beside Degas's pastels of criminal physiognomies, critics read the child's face as a criminal type; she was dismissed from the Opéra the following year for missed classes and then disappears from the record. The point bears directly on the argument. The historical ballet academy was an institution in which girls were formed as artists and sold as bodies, and in which mothers could act as the brokers of their daughters. *Suspiria*'s coven, a sorority of teachers who prepare girls for a hidden sovereign, is a fantasy built on that institution.

6.5 German movement culture on the Upper Rhine

Although the academy is nominally classical, it stands on a German substrate of esoteric and reformist dance. Émile Jaques-Dalcroze opened his institute for eurhythmics at Hellerau in 1911. Rudolf von Laban taught at the Monte Verità colony near Ascona from 1913, where dance, vegetarianism, sun worship, and occultism mixed. Mary Wigman, Laban's pupil, created her *Hexentanz*, *Witch Dance*, first conceived in 1914 at Monte Verità, and its masked solo version in 1926, one of the founding works of German expressive dance. A third version, for a group, followed in 1934 under the Third Reich as part of her Frauentänze (Women's Dances), a version that, as Alexandra Kolb has observed, the secondary literature often leaves unmentioned. Rudolf Steiner developed eurythmy, his "visible speech," from 1912, and taught it at Dornach, near Basel, in the border triangle that Argento named as the origin of his fascination. Steiner's first Goetheanum, a double-domed wooden temple

of the arts, burned to the ground on the night of 31 December 1922. The later entanglement of German expressive dance with National Socialism — Laban's service to the regime and his fall from favour in 1936, Wigman's accommodations, the dancer's training of Leni Riefenstahl, who made her screen debut as a dancer in Arnold Fanck's *Der heilige Berg* (1926) — completes the genealogy.

Guadagnino's 2018 film excavated this substrate explicitly, turning the academy into a company of German expressive dance whose signature work is called *Volk*. The 1977 film keeps it latent. But the occult school of the Upper Rhine, the witch dance, and the temple that burned are the historical figures of which the Tanz Akademie is the dream.

6.6 The pedagogical province inverted

The *Bildungsroman* has its own secret societies. In Goethe's *Wilhelm Meisters Lehrjahre* (1795–1796), the hero discovers at the end that his wanderings and errors have been observed and guided throughout by the Society of the Tower, which hands him his indenture, the *Lehrbrief*, as a certificate of completed apprenticeship. The same novel contains Mignon, the Italian child acrobat who performs a blindfolded dance among eggs and sings "Kennst du das Land, wo die Zitronen blühn," her longing for Italy; after her death her embalmed body is laid out in the Society's Hall of the Past. In the *Wanderjahre* (1821/1829) Goethe imagined a Pedagogical Province in which education is total and benevolent, and Hermann Hesse's *Das Glasperlenspiel* (1943) gave the idea its twentieth-century form in Castalia.

Suspiria is the dark Pedagogical Province. Its Society of the Tower is a coven; its indenture is a hex; its Hall of the Past holds Sara's mutilated corpse; and it is an Italian film about a German school, Mignon's situation reversed, Italy dreaming Germany. The literature of the sinister school supplies its closer kin. Robert Walser's *Jakob von Gunten* (1909) describes the Benjamenta Institute, a school for servants whose pupils whisper about its forbidden inner chambers; Lisa Benjamenta leads Jakob through them, and when she dies the Institute dissolves. Musil's *Die Verwirrungen des Zöglings Törleß* (1906) found cruelty and metaphysics in a military boarding school. Kafka's "In der Strafkolonie" (1919) imagined an apparatus that writes the sentence on the condemned man's body, so that understanding dawns on him, the officer says, around the sixth hour, beginning at the eyes: education by inscription in the flesh. Frank Wedekind's *Mine-Haha* (1903) described girls raised in a walled park and trained in bodily movement and dance for performances before an unseen audience; Lucile Hadžihalilović adapted it as *Innocence* (2004). Peter Weir's *Picnic at Hanging Rock* (1975) set its vanishing schoolgirls in 1900; Pasolini's *Salò* (1975) enclosed eighteen adolescents, rounded up by fascist militiamen in the Republic of Salò, in a villa organized like Dante's circles, where four libertines — the Duke, the Bishop, the Magistrate, and the President, figures of aristocracy, church, law, and state — subject them to sexual abuse, torture, and finally murder. Three older women narrate stories that instruct and inflame the masters, and a fourth accompanies them at the piano until, near the end, she kills herself by leaping from a window. Pasolini's narrators are the regime's matrons, the voices of an infernal curriculum, as Madame Blanc and Miss Tanner are the Mother's.

Franco Moretti's *The Way of the World* (1987) described the *Bildungsroman* as the symbolic form of modernity, the narrative that reconciles the individual's self-development with socialization.

Suspiria refuses the reconciliation. Its heroine's formation does not end in her integration into the institution that formed her. It ends with the institution in flames.

6.7 The path of despair, and the refusal of sublation

Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807), published in the same year as Jean Paul's *Levana*, narrates the education of consciousness along a *Weg der Verzweiflung*, a path of despair. Its Preface declares that the life of Spirit is not the life that shrinks from death but the life that endures it and maintains itself in it: "Er gewinnt seine Wahrheit nur, indem er in der absoluten Zerrissenheit sich selbst findet" — it wins its truth only when it finds itself in utter dismemberment. Spirit is breath, *Geist*, *spiritus*; its formation passes through dismemberment; its method is to tarry with the negative. M. H. Abrams read the *Phenomenology* as the philosophical form of the Romantic circuitous journey (1971). It is De Quincey's commission in the vocabulary of the concept, and *Suspiria* is full of dismemberment.

But the film does not complete the Hegelian movement. Carla Lonzi's *Sputiamo su Hegel* (1970), a founding text of Italian feminism, argued that the dialectic is the logic by which patriarchal culture absorbs and neutralizes women's difference, and called for a female subjectivity that would not pass through the master's sublation. Suzy's formation is not an *Aufhebung*, a negation preserved and raised into a higher unity with the institution. It is a succession: the pupil kills the head of the school and walks out of the burning house. Part Four reads that succession politically and mythically.

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PART THREE · THE APPARATUS

CHAPTER

VII

Argus and Actaeon

The Ocular Regime and Its Overthrow

So shall he see the things that ought not to be seen.

DE QUINCEY · "LEVANA"

Suspiria belongs to a director obsessed with seeing, but it organizes sight as an instrument of the Mothers — the gaze from the dark that precedes and kills, the guide that devours the blind, the hundred eyes set in glass — and its climax turns that instrument against its owner: the heroine kills the invisible breath with a weapon made of eyes, in a flash of light that is at once a lightning-stroke, a radiograph, and an initiation.

7.1 The drinking eye

Augustine left the founding description of the spectator of violence. His friend Alypius, dragged by companions to the gladiatorial games, shut his eyes; a roar from the crowd made him open them; and, Augustine writes, as soon as he saw the blood he drank in the savagery, fixed his gaze, "hauriebat furias et nesciebat" — drank in the Furies and did not know it — and grew drunk on bloody pleasure (*Confessions* VI.8). Later Augustine names the vice *concupiscentia oculorum*, the lust of the eyes, and observes that curiosity drives people to look even at a mangled corpse that horrifies them (X.35). The drinking eye, the Furies imbibed through sight, and the corpse that repels and attracts are the three terms of a theory of horror spectatorship formulated fifteen centuries before the genre.

Augustine's scene contains a detail that bears directly on *Suspiria*. Alypius closed his eyes but not his ears — "atque utinam et aures opturasset!", Augustine exclaims, would that he had stopped his ears as well — and it was the roar of the crowd, "qui per eius aures intravit et reseravit eius lumina," which entered through his ears and unlocked his eyes. In the founding text of the spectatorship of violence, the ear opens the eye. That is the order of knowledge in *Suspiria*, as Chapter 4 argued: the breath, the wind-torn words, and the counted footsteps come first, and sight follows them.

Argento's *gialli* made that theory an epistemology. In *L'uccello dalle piume di cristallo* (1970) a witness sees an attack through a gallery's glass wall and misreads it; in *Profondo rosso* (1975) the detective looks straight at the killer's face in a mirror without recognizing it; both films descend from Antonioni's *Blow-Up* (1966), whose star David Hemmings Argento cast in *Profondo rosso*. Truth in these films is a detail seen but not understood. *Opera* (1987) would push the logic to its limit, taping needles beneath the heroine's eyes so that she cannot close them while murders are committed in front of her: the spectator as Alypius, forced to look and to drink. *Suspiria* stands between these films and transforms their premise. Its decisive knowledge, as Chapter 4 showed, comes by ear. The eye in *Suspiria* belongs to the Mothers.

Italian Gothic had already joined the witch to the lethal look; the first version of this chapter cut the connection for length. Gogol's "Viy" (1835) sends a seminary student, Khoma Brut, to read the office for three nights over the body of a young woman who is a witch — a witch he had himself beaten to death after she rode him through the night. On the third night she summons the Viy, a chthonic being whose eyelids reach the ground; when its servants lift them, the student, warned not to look, looks; the Viy sees him, and he dies. Mario Bava's *La maschera del demonio* (1960), loosely drawn from Gogol, opens with the execution of the witch-princess Asa, condemned to death for witchcraft by her own brother, the Grand Inquisitor, who has a spiked iron mask fixed onto her face before she is put to death; two centuries later she returns to drain the living. Both stories make a student or a lineage the victim of a female power that kills by seeing and being seen. *Suspiria* inherits the pairing of student and witch and reverses the outcome: here the student sees the hidden witch and survives.

7.2 The eyes in the dark

The first murder begins with a reversal of looking. Pat Hingle, sheltering in a friend's apartment, goes to a window and sees nothing outside but darkness — until two eyes appear in it, looking back. An arm smashes through the glass; she is stabbed repeatedly, bound by a noose, and thrown through the building's stained-glass skylight to hang above the lobby, while a falling shard impales her friend below. The girl is seen before she sees. Lacan's eleventh seminar (1964, published 1973) located the gaze not in the subject's eye but on the side of the object, in the world that looks back; the subject sees from one point but is looked at from everywhere. *Suspiria* opens with that structure made literal: the eyes in the dark are the gaze of the house, and Pat is already inside its picture.

The skylight is the second term. Abbot Suger, rebuilding Saint-Denis in the 1140s, filled the choir with colored glass and justified it by an anagogical method: material light passing through colored windows would lead the mind upward to the immaterial light of God. The stained-glass window is

the theological instrument of elevation — of Levana's *levare*, lifting the soul. *Suspiria*'s first murder breaks the anagogical window and reverses its motion. The colored glass does not raise Pat toward heaven; it suspends her by the neck above the floor. Lifting becomes hanging, and the shards of the window become blades.

7.3 Daniel at the Königsplatz

Daniel, the academy's blind pianist, is dismissed by Miss Tanner after his German shepherd bites Albert, Madame Blanc's nephew. That night he crosses a vast, empty square, senses an unseen presence, and is killed when his dog turns on him and tears out his throat. The scene was shot on the Königsplatz in Munich, and the location is a palimpsest. Leo von Klenze built the Glyptothek and the Propyläen there for Ludwig I as a Hellenic forum for the arts. The National Socialists made it their ceremonial center: party buildings rose at its eastern edge, two "temples of honor" held the remains of the Nazis killed in the 1923 putsch, the square was paved in granite in 1935 for mass rallies, and on 10 May 1933, as in university towns across Germany, Nazi students burned there the books of Jewish, socialist, pacifist, and other proscribed authors. The temples were blown up in 1947; the paving survived until the late 1980s. When Argento filmed in 1976, the blind man died on the parade ground of the regime. The emptiness of the square in the scene is the emptiness of a stage built for crowds.

The mythic grid is dense. Actaeon, the hunter who came upon Diana bathing, was turned into a stag and torn apart by his own hounds, whose names Ovid catalogues (*Metamorphoses* III). Tiresias was blinded for seeing Athena bathe, in Callimachus' version, or by Juno for revealing that women take greater pleasure in love, in Ovid's, and received prophecy in compensation. Pentheus, in Euripides' *Bacchae*, spied on the women's rites and was torn apart by his own mother. Hecate, goddess of the witches, is attended by dogs in Greek poetry. Daniel is a Tiresias who has already paid with his eyes and an Actaeon who is nevertheless devoured: a man in the service of women's art, killed by his own guide, the animal that served as his prosthetic sight. The apparatus of vision turns on the blind. And De Quincey had already written the scene in grief's register: Mater Lachrymarum sitting at the bedside of the blind beggar whose guiding child has died, who "dreams at midnight that the little guiding hand is locked within his own."

The name completes the figure. In the Greek additions to the Book of Daniel, two elders spy on Susanna as she bathes in her garden and demand that she submit to them sexually, threatening, if she refuses, to accuse her of adultery with a young man, a capital charge. She refuses; they accuse her; she is condemned to death; and the young Daniel saves her by questioning the two separately and exposing their perjury (Daniel 13). The episode became a privileged subject of European painting, and Artemisia Gentileschi's *Susanna and the Elders* (1610) rendered it, unusually, from the woman's side of the gaze. *Suspiria* has a Suzy and a Daniel, a scene at the academy's pool in which the girls confide their fears, and elders who watch. Its Daniel is blind and is killed; there is no one to expose the watchers on Susanna's behalf, and she must do it herself.

Artemisia's own history bears on the film's theme of testimony, and the first version of this chapter left it out. In 1611, the year after she painted *Susanna*, she was raped by the painter Agostino

Tassi, her father's collaborator and her teacher in perspective. At the trial her father brought in 1612, the court tested the truth of her testimony by torturing her with thumbscrews; Tassi was convicted and sentenced to banishment from Rome, a sentence that was never enforced. The painting predates the assault and should not be read as its record. But the sequence — a young woman painting the predatory gaze from the victim's side, then made, as a victim, to prove her word under torture — is the historical form of what Chapter 2 called the disavowed memorate: a woman's testimony about men in power, tested and doubted by the institution that judges it.

7.4 Reason and witchcraft

Suzy seeks explanation from two men, and the setting of the conversation is chosen with care. The production record places her meeting with the psychiatrist Frank Mandel outside BMW's Munich headquarters, the four-cylinder tower completed in 1973: the architecture of corporate and technological rationality. Mandel dismisses witchcraft as mental illness, holding that misfortune comes from broken minds rather than broken mirrors. The aged occultist Professor Milius affirms that covens exist, tells Suzy that a coven draws its strength from its leader, and adds that without its head the coven perishes.

The exchange stages a century-old dispute. Jean-Martin Charcot and Paul Richer's *Les Démoniaques dans l'art* (1887) re-diagnosed the possessed women of religious painting as hysterics, and the photographic albums of the Salpêtrière, whose construction Georges Didi-Huberman analyzed in *Invention de l'hystérie* (1982), made the hysteric a spectacle. Freud, in letters to Fliess of January 1897, noted that the medieval theory of possession resembled his own theory of hysteria and ordered a copy of the *Malleus maleficarum*; he later read a painter's pact with the devil as a neurosis (1923). Michel de Certeau's *La Possession de Loudun* (1970) reconstructed the possession of an Ursuline convent in the 1630s as a contest between physicians and theologians over the bodies of women in an institution, a contest that ended when the parish priest Urbain Grandier, accused by the prioress Jeanne des Anges and her nuns of having bewitched them, was tried by a commission under Jean de Laubardemont, sent by Cardinal Richelieu, tortured, and burned alive in August 1634; Aldous Huxley's *The Devils of Loudun* (1952) and Ken Russell's *The Devils* (1971) had made the case notorious. Mandel speaks for Charcot, Milius for the exorcists, and the film, like the convent, belongs to neither. Tzvetan Todorov defined the fantastic as the reader's hesitation between natural and supernatural explanation (1970), resolving either into the uncanny or into the marvelous. *Suspiria* hesitates until Milius speaks, and then commits to the marvelous.

One onomastic detail may be noted in the spirit of Benjamin's doctrine of non-sensuous similarity, and only in that spirit. *Mandel* is German for almond; the anatomist Karl Friedrich Burdach, in his Vom Baue und Leben des Gehirns (1819–1826), named the brain's almond-shaped nucleus — in German still the Mandelkern, the almond kernel — the *amygdala*, Greek for almond. In 1937 Heinrich Klüver and Paul Bucy showed that monkeys deprived of their temporal lobes, amygdala included, lose their fear. The man who explains fear away bears, in German, the name of the organ without which fear disappears.

7.5 The eyes of Argus

Suzy wakes the sleeping Mother by breaking a decorative glass peacock, and she kills her with one of its broken glass quills. The bird is not ornamental chance. The peacock belongs to Hera, Juno in Latin, and its tail carries the eyes of Argus Panoptes, the hundred-eyed watchman whom Juno set to guard Io. Ovid tells how Mercury, disguised as a shepherd, lulled Argus with the music of the panpipe and the story of its invention — the nymph Syrinx, fleeing Pan, turned into reeds, from which Pan made the pipe — until every one of the hundred eyes closed; Mercury then cut off his head, and Juno set the eyes in the peacock's tail (*Metamorphoses* I).

The myth and the film form an exact chiasmus. In Ovid, breath — the music of a pipe made from a girl's transformed body — closes the hundred eyes, and decapitation follows. In *Suspiria*, the shattered eyes wake the breath, and the eyes, made glass, pierce the throat and stop it. The watched girl seizes the instrument of watching. Jeremy Bentham's Panopticon (1791), which Foucault made the diagram of disciplinary power, places the inmate under an invisible eye; Suzy turns the hundred eyes into a blade and drives them into the invisible one.

The instrument also carries a mythic politics. Hera is the Olympian matron, the goddess of marriage and of the order of Zeus; the Mother of Sighs belongs to the chthonic powers that Bachofen saw defeated by Olympian law. The matricide is thus an Oresteia between women, in which the emblem of the Olympian wife kills the chthonic mother. Whether the American girl acts for a new order or merely replaces the old head is the question of Chapters 9 and 10. A last similarity, offered again under Benjamin's caution: the director's name means silver, the halide in which photography fixes light, and the eyes of Argus kill the Mother in a film whose imbibition prints contain no silver image at all.

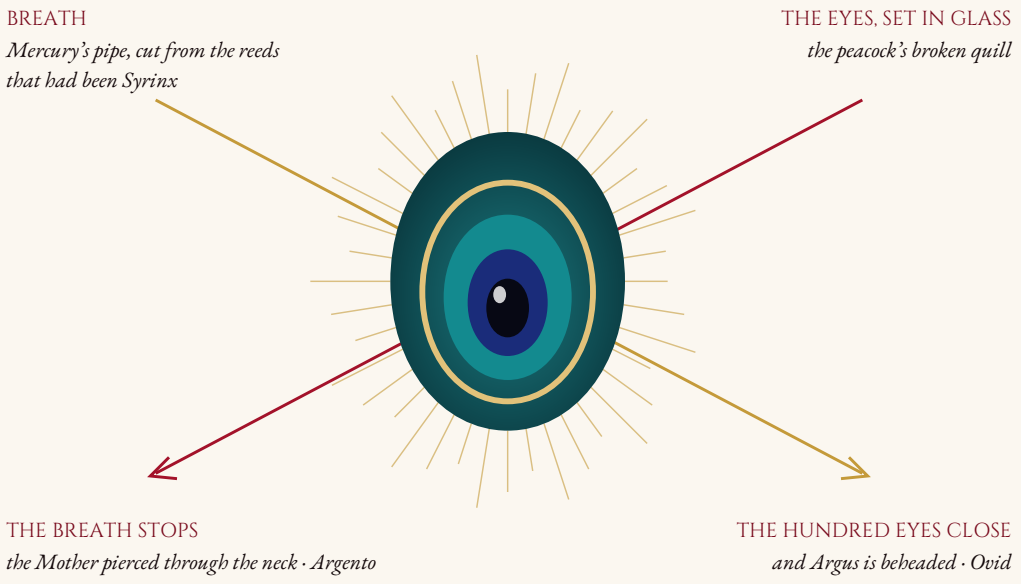


FIGURE 10 *The chiasmus of Argus: in Ovid breath closes the hundred eyes; in Argento the eyes, made glass, stop the breath.*

7.6 Lightning

The Mother can be killed only because she can be seen, and she can be seen only by lightning. The production record states that flashes of lightning reveal Markos's silhouette, and in that instant Suzy strikes. Three histories converge on the flash.

The first is radiographic. On 8 November 1895, at Würzburg, Wilhelm Röntgen discovered the rays that pass through flesh; on 22 December he made a radiograph of his wife Anna Bertha's hand, ring and bones visible, and she reportedly said that she had seen her death. A flash that renders an invisible body visible as an outline in light is the X-ray's primal scene, and the academy, as Chapter 8 shows, was founded that year. The second is initiatory. Ancient sources compare the Eleusinian mysteries to a passage through darkness and terror toward a sudden, overwhelming light; Hippolytus — a hostile Christian witness, though one that historians of the mysteries have often taken seriously — reports that the hierophant, at night and under a great fire, cried that the Mistress had borne a holy child, Brimo to Brimos, and that the supreme sight of the rite was a reaped ear of wheat shown in silence (*Refutatio* V.8.39–40), and Apuleius' initiate says, "nocte media vidi solem candido coruscantem lumine" — at midnight I saw the sun shining with brilliant light (*Metamorphoses* XI.23). Suzy's ordeal follows the initiatory pattern exactly: wandering in dark corridors, terror before a reanimated corpse, and then the flash in which the hidden deity appears. But where the Eleusinian cry announced that a Mother had given birth, the film's flash reveals a Mother to be killed, and the child born of the ordeal is the daughter who walks out of it.

The third is epistemological. In his 1923 lecture on the serpent ritual of the Pueblo, Aby Warburg read the serpent as the archaic symbol of lightning, a figure that kept a space for thought — *Denkraum* — between human beings and the forces of nature, and he lamented that captured electricity, the lightning conducted into wire, was destroying that space. Walter Benjamin wrote in the *Arcades* notes that in the domains with which he was concerned knowledge comes only in lightning flashes, and in his theses on history that the true image of the past flits by, flashing up at the instant it becomes recognizable. *Suspiria*'s lightning is uncaptured electricity, Warburg's archaic flash, and Benjamin's dialectical image at once: the instant in which the invisible origin becomes legible, and, being legible, becomes mortal. It is also the emblem of this dissertation's method, which reads the film by constellations that appear in such flashes.

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PART THREE · THE APPARATUS

CHAPTER

VIII

Anno 1895

The Academy as Apparatus

They conspired together; and on the mirrors of darkness my eye traced the plots.

DE QUINCEY · "LEVANA"

The film dates the academy precisely — Mandel tells Suzy it was founded in 1895 by Helena Markos, a Greek émigrée reputed to be a witch — and that date makes the Mother of Sighs coeval with the three apparatuses through which modernity learned to see and hear the invisible interior: the cinematograph, the radiograph, and psychoanalysis; read in that light, the academy is an allegory of the cinema as a maternal machine.

8.1 The year of the founding

The date is a grade-three constellation in the terms of the Introduction: no evidence suggests that Argento or Nicolodi chose it for its resonance. Its density is nonetheless extraordinary. The following events all belong to 1895.

DATE IN 1895	EVENT	BEARING ON THE ACADEMY
January	Petipa and Ivanov's definitive *Swan Lake*, Mariinsky Theatre, St Petersburg	The canonical ballet of maidens enchanted by a sorcerer
During the year	Breuer and Freud, *Studien über Hysterie*	Women's speech as cure; Anna O.'s "talking cure"

DATE IN 1895	EVENT	BEARING ON THE ACADEMY
During the year	Gustave Le Bon, *Psychologie des foules*	The crowd, suggestion, and the hypnotic leader
During the year	H. G. Wells, *The Time Machine*	Beautiful surface youth preyed on by a hidden subterranean caste
Night of 23–24 July	Freud's dream of Irma's injection	A look into a woman's throat; the specimen dream of psychoanalysis
Summer and autumn	Marconi's wireless experiments near Bologna	Signal without wire or body
8 November	Röntgen discovers X-rays at Würzburg; radiograph of Anna Bertha Röntgen's hand, 22 December	The invisible interior made visible as an outline in light
28 December	First paid public screening of the Lumière Cinématographe, Grand Café, Paris	The apparatus of moving images

The list is not a causal chain. It is a constellation in Benjamin's sense: the stars are independent, the figure they make is legible only from a particular point of view, and that point of view is the film's. From there the academy appears as the fictional institution that the year was building in reality — a house of girls trained in an art of enchanted maidens, governed by a hypnotic leader through suggestion, in which a hidden caste consumes the young, a woman's throat is the site of revelation, a voice travels without a body, an invisible body appears as an outline of light, and the whole is, finally, projected.

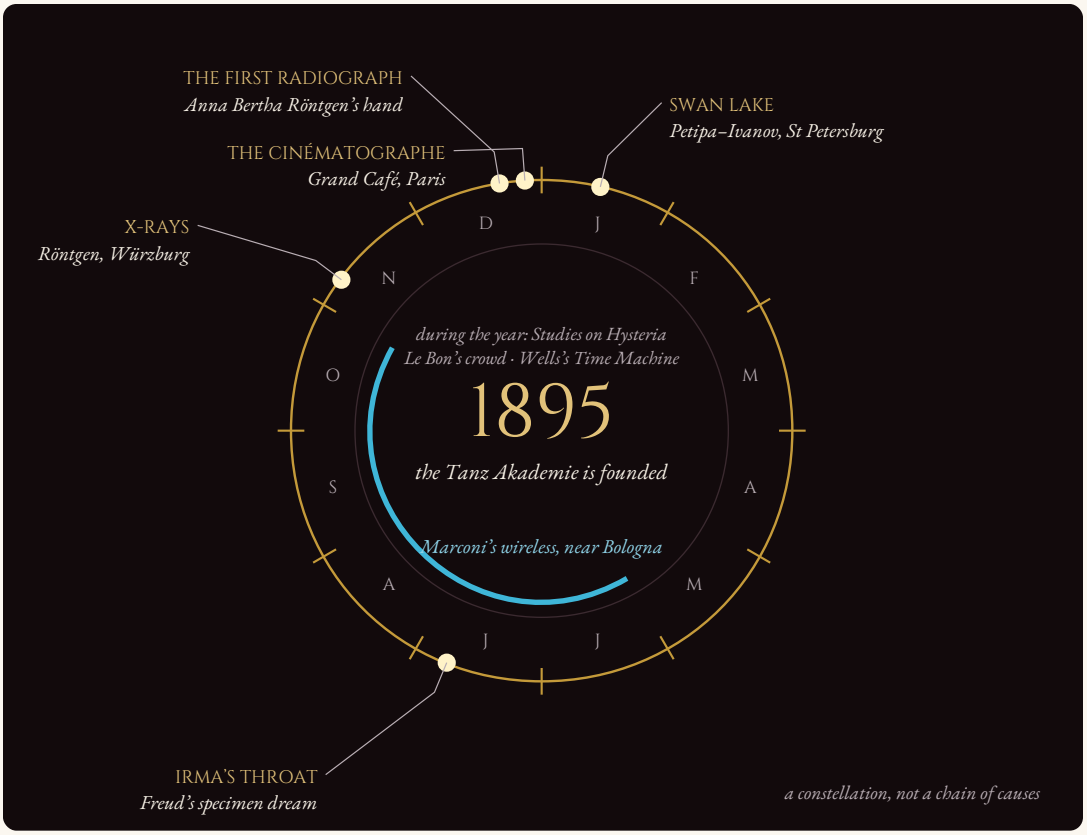


FIGURE 11 *Anno 1895: the year of the academy's founding, read as a constellation.*

8.2 Three apparatuses of the invisible interior

Cinema, radiography, and psychoanalysis share a structure: each renders visible or audible an interior that had been inaccessible. Cinema animates the photographic shadow; a year after the Lumière premiere, Maxim Gorky reviewed a screening at the Nizhny Novgorod fair as a visit to a kingdom of shadows, a grey and soundless world that was not life but its specter. Radiography sees through flesh to the skeleton of the living, and its first iconic image was a woman's hand, which made its subject see her own death. Psychoanalysis makes the interior of the mind audible through the speech of women diagnosed as hysterics. In each case the interior revealed is gendered, and in each the revelation borders on death.

Freud's dream of Irma's injection, dreamed in July 1895 and analyzed in *The Interpretation of Dreams* as the specimen of the method, turns on a look into a woman's throat: Freud examines his patient Irma's mouth and sees white patches and scabby formations. Lacan, in his second seminar (1954–1955), read this moment as an encounter with the Real — the flesh that is never seen, the abyss from which life emerges, a sight that undoes the dreamer. The founding dream of psychoanalysis is a look into the throat of a woman. The founding Mother of *Suspiria* dies by a wound to the

throat. Between Freud and Argento the throat passes from the object of a horrified gaze to the target of a glass quill made of eyes: the site where the Real was glimpsed becomes the site where it is closed.

The academy assembles the three apparatuses in its own idiom. Pat's heart, laid bare by the knife in the first murder, is an anatomical display, the interior made spectacle. Markos's invisible body, revealed by a flash as a silhouette, is a radiograph. And the whole house runs on a woman's breath and voice, heard but not seen: the interior speaks.

8.3 Apparatus theory as a theory of the Mother

In the years just before the film, French theory described the cinema itself as a maternal machine. Jean-Louis Baudry's "Effets idéologiques produits par l'appareil de base" (1970) and "Le dispositif" (1975) argued that the cinema reproduces the conditions of Plato's cave — a dark room, immobilized viewers, images projected from behind them — and that its pleasure lies in a regression to an early state in which perception and representation, wish and hallucination, are not yet distinguished. Baudry drew on the psychoanalyst Bertram Lewin's concept of the "dream screen" (1946), the surface onto which a dream appears to be projected, which Lewin identified with the mother's breast, flattened in the sleeper's perception after feeding. The infant's first sleep, Lewin argued, follows oral satiety and has no visual content, so that in the absence of images "the dream screen would be blank"; the screen also represents the fulfillment of the wish to sleep. Christian Metz's *Le Signifiant imaginaire* (1977) added the spectator's primary identification with the camera, the all-perceiving eye, and defined the cinematic signifier as the presence of an absence.

Suspiria stages this theory as a scene. When maggots drive the students from their rooms, they sleep together in a dark hall behind white sheets hung around its walls; a shadow moves behind the sheet; the Mother breathes. That is Plato's cave, Baudry's *dispositif*, and Lewin's dream screen at once: immobile sleepers in the dark, a white screen, a shadow, the maternal presence behind the surface. The drugged wine is the spectator's motor inhibition and, in Lewin's terms, the oral satiety that precedes the dream: the girls drink, sleep, and see on a white sheet the shadow of the Mother whose breath they hear. Lewin's blank dream screen, Güldenstubbé's blank sheet awaiting the spirits' writing (Chapter 4), and Technicolor's blank receiving film (Chapter 5) are three versions of one receptive surface, and the film stages all three. The film does not need apparatus theory to explain it; it is apparatus theory dreamed as a fairy tale.

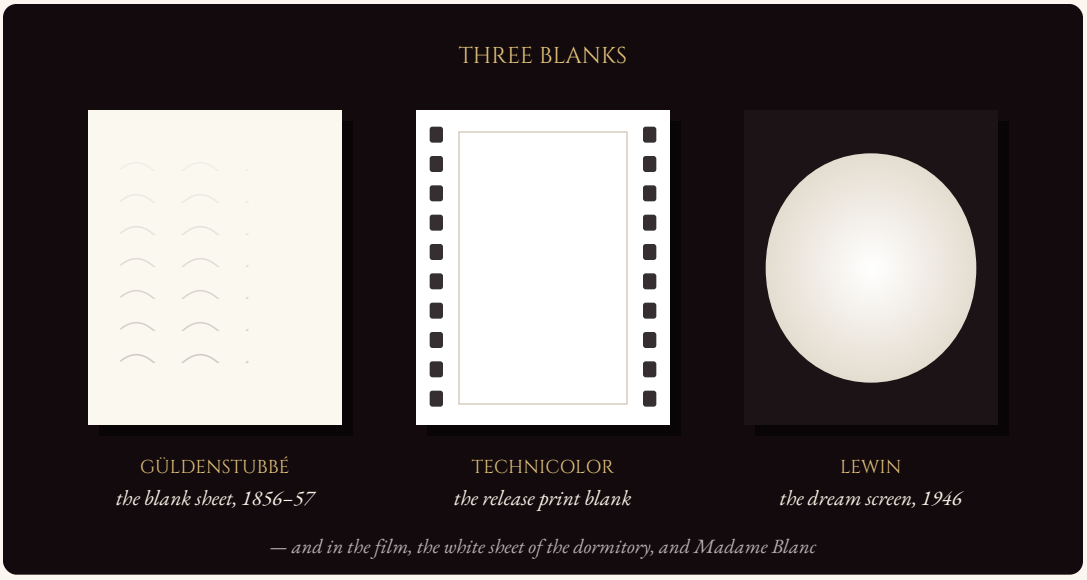


FIGURE 12 *Three blanks: the spiritualist's sheet, the laboratory's receiving film and the psychoanalyst's dream screen.*

8.4 From the Mother's mouth to the media

Friedrich Kittler supplied the history that apparatus theory lacked. In *Aufschreibesysteme 1800/1900* (1985) he argued that the discourse network of 1800 rested on the mother's voice: the mother teaching her child to read aloud, the child internalizing her voice as the voice of nature, and *Bildung* built on that interiorized maternal speech. The discourse network of 1900 replaced her with technical media. *Grammophon, Film, Typewriter* (1986) described how phonograph and film record directly what writing could only signify — voices, breaths, movements — so that the mother is no longer the source of discourse but one of its recorded objects. Kittler also read Novalis's Klingsohr tale as an allegory of the primary socialization that Heinrich's mother was meant to narrate (Chapter 10 returns to that tale's burning of the Mother).

The Mother of Sighs, who founds her academy in 1895, is the figure of this transition. Levana belongs to 1800: an invisible goddess of education who forms the child through feeling. Markos belongs to 1900: a breath and a voice that operate a house of bodies like a machine, transmitted through an intercom, a score recorded before the action, and dialogue re-breathed after it. The academy is the mother's mouth in the process of becoming the apparatus.

8.5 The mummy and the reanimated daughter

André Bazin opened "Ontologie de l'image photographique" (1945) with the "mummy complex": the plastic arts begin in the embalming of the dead, and photography and cinema fulfil the wish to preserve the body against time, cinema adding to the photograph the embalming of change itself. The academy keeps its dead. Sara's mutilated corpse is stored in an alcove, and at the climax the Mother animates it and sends it against Suzy, moving it from outside as a puppeteer moves a doll.

Goethe's Society of the Tower had laid Mignon's embalmed body in its Hall of the Past (Chapter 6); Markos does more, and does what the cinema does: she makes the dead girl move. When the Mother dies, the corpse vanishes. The reanimation lasts exactly as long as the apparatus runs.

8.6 The speculative fiction of the fin de siècle

The literature of the 1890s imagined the academy before the film did. Arthur Machen's *The Great God Pan* (1894) begins with Dr. Raymond operating on the brain of Mary, a girl he had taken in as a destitute child and regards as his to use, so that she may see the god; the experiment destroys her mind, and she later gives birth to Helen Vaughan, whose acquaintance drives a series of men in London to suicide, and who, dying, dissolves through every form of life. Wells's *The Time Machine* (1895) divides humanity into the beautiful, childlike Eloi on the surface and the Morlocks below, who feed on them. Bram Stoker's *Dracula* (1897) places three women in the Count's castle, whose breath Jonathan Harker feels upon his throat; denied him, they are given instead a child the Count has carried in, and when the child's mother comes to the castle gate crying for it, the Count summons wolves that kill her. Van Helsing later destroys the three. A triad of women fed on a child, and a mother lamenting at a gate that will not open: Stoker's castle stages De Quincey's Rachel at the denied gate of Chapter 1. Oscar Wilde's *Salomé*, staged in Paris in 1896 and set by Richard Strauss in 1905, made the dancing girl who demands a head the emblem of the period. Warburg's *Ninfa* — the striding girl in fluttering drapery in Ghirlandaio's frescoes in Santa Maria Novella, whom he traced back to the maenad and forward to Judith and Salome bearing a severed head — gave that emblem its iconological history.

These texts converge on a name. In Stesichorus' *Palinode* and Euripides' *Helen* (412 BCE), the Helen who went to Troy was only an *eidolon*, an image, while the real woman waited in Egypt; Greeks and Trojans fought for a phantom. In *Faust II*, Faust descends to the Mothers in order to bring back Helena, who appears as a conjured image; when he tries to seize her, there is an explosion and he falls senseless. Machen's Helen is a phantasm born of a surgical unveiling. *Suspiria*'s Mother is named Helena, and for most of the film she is exactly an *eidolon* without a body — a breath, a voice, a shadow on a sheet, an outline in lightning. The name of the invisible Mother is the ancient name of the image that is not a body. What the Mothers keep, in Goethe, is images of every creature; what Helena is, in Euripides, is an image; what the cinema is, for Gorky, is a kingdom of shadows. The academy founded in 1895 is the house of such images, and the girl who kills its Mother, unlike Faust, does not fall when she seizes Helena.

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PART FOUR · THE FURNACE

CHAPTER

IX

Tremate, Tremate

Witches, Mourning, and the Politics of 1977

Hush! whisper whilst we talk of her!

DE QUINCEY · "LEVANA"

Suspiria appeared at the moment when Italian feminism was reclaiming the witch and West Germany was failing to mourn its past, and its coven condenses both histories into one ambivalent figure — a sovereign female institution that is at once the misogynist nightmare of the witch-hunters and the utopia of a symbolic order of women — whose destruction the film cannot decide whether to celebrate or to inherit.

9.1 The witches have returned

In the Italian feminist marches of the 1970s, women chanted *Tremate, tremate, le streghe son tornate*: tremble, tremble, the witches have returned. The slogan compressed a decade. Rivolta Femminile was founded in 1970, and its co-founder Carla Lonzi published *Sputiamo su Hegel* that year. Lotta Femminista formed in Padua in 1971; Mariarosa Dalla Costa and Selma James published *The Power of Women and the Subversion of the Community* in 1972, launching the international campaign for wages for housework in which Silvia Federici took part. Divorce, legalized in 1970, survived a referendum in 1974; abortion would be legalized in May 1978. Feminist historiography joined the movement. Luisa Muraro's *La Signora del gioco* (1976), subtitled "episodes of the witch-hunt," was built largely out of trial records and proposed to let the accused women tell their own story and to give

credit to the victims as a matter of principle — the opposite of the disavowal with which Chapter 2 saw the grandmother's memorate met. It noticed how often the confessions turned on a female figure, the "Lady of the game," whose nocturnal "game" was a gathering of feasting and dance. Carlo Ginzburg, who took up and developed the figure while judging Muraro's interpretation of the confessions misleading, and whose *I benandanti* (1966) had uncovered a Friulian agrarian cult of night battles, would later trace in *Storia notturna* (1989) the nocturnal processions of women following a goddess. The late-fourteenth-century trials at Milan of women who confessed to frequenting the "society" of a nocturnal lady they called Madonna Oriente had already given Italy its own documented night-mother.

Italian anthropology had prepared the ground. Ernesto de Martino's *Morte e pianto rituale nel mondo antico* (1958) traced ritual lament from pagan mourning to the Virgin's lament for her son, describing lament as a cultural technique for mastering the crisis of grief; his *Sud e magia* (1959) and *La terra del rimorso* (1961) studied the magic of the South and the tarantism of Apulia, in which women "bitten" by the tarantula danced to music for days to be cured. A tradition of women's grief transformed into ritual — the Mother of Tears — and of women's affliction cured by dance under a spider's spell lay inside Italian scholarship when Argento and Nicolodi wrote. Federici's *Caliban and the Witch* (2004) would later give the 1970s rediscovery its theoretical summa, reading the European witch-hunt as part of capitalism's primitive accumulation, a war on women's control over reproduction and on the common knowledge of women.

Suspiria was released on 1 February 1977, in the year of the Movement of '77. In March the police closed Radio Alice, the autonomist station in Bologna named after Carroll's heroine. The witches had returned, and so had Alice. The film gives them an institution.

The first version of this chapter omitted the political violence that framed that year, and the omission weakened section 9.3, which left Germany alone with an unmourned fascist past. Italy had its own. The broad amnesty of June 1946, issued under the Communist justice minister Palmiro Togliatti, released or spared a great many Fascists accused or convicted of crimes; Italy held no reckoning comparable to Nuremberg; and the postwar legend of *italiani brava gente*, Italians as decent people, kept the regime's colonial and wartime crimes out of public memory. From 1969 that past returned as bombs, in what came to be called the strategy of tension. On 12 December 1969 a bomb in the Banca Nazionale dell'Agricoltura in Milan's Piazza Fontana killed seventeen people and wounded eighty-eight. Investigators first pursued anarchists — one of them, Giuseppe Pinelli, died three days later in a fall from a fourth-floor window of Milan police headquarters, where he was being held for questioning, a death Dario Fo satirized in *Morte accidentale di un anarchico* (1970) — but the judgments that followed traced the attack to the neo-fascist organization Ordine Nuovo. In 2005 the Court of Cassation confirmed the acquittal of the last defendants while recognizing the responsibility of Franco Freda and Giovanni Ventura, leaders of the group's Paduan cell, who could no longer be tried because they had been definitively acquitted decades earlier; the group's explosives expert, Carlo Digilio, had confessed. On 28 May 1974 a bomb at an anti-fascist trade-union rally in Brescia's Piazza della Loggia killed eight people and wounded 102; in 2017 the Cassation made final the life sentences of Carlo Maria Maggi, leader of Ordine Nuovo in the Veneto, as the attack's instigator, and of Maurizio Tramonte, a secret-service informant inside the group, and further proceedings have

continued since. The magistrates who investigated these attacks also documented heavy misdirection of the inquiries by parts of the intelligence services and the political world of the time. The ideological lineage of these groups ran in part through Julius Evola, the esoteric traditionalist of the Gruppo di Ur (1927–1929), whom Ordine Nuovo, founded in 1956, took as a master. From the opposite extreme, the Red Brigades kidnapped the former prime minister Aldo Moro in March 1978, killing the five men of his escort, and murdered him in May.

This history changes the reading of the film's geography. An Italian film written and shot in the middle of the strategy of tension locates its occult sovereign, its fascist parade ground, and its unmourned past in Germany. The displacement is itself a symptom. Italy's own fascist inheritance — an occult traditionalism that fed a terrorism of the right, protected by parts of the state — returns in the film as a German coven: a hidden and ancient authority, served by a secret apparatus, whose violence the official order refuses to see. The Mother of Sighs presides over the unmourned past of both countries, and the Italian past is the nearer one.

9.2 The coven as dystopia and utopia

The coven of *Suspiria* is a self-governing community of women that owns property, runs an enterprise, educates the young, controls its own reproduction through succession rather than birth, and excludes men from power. Its men are blind (Daniel), mute or nearly so (the servant Pavlos), children (Albert), ineffectual (the student Mark), or merely explanatory (Mandel and Milius). Read from the *Malleus maleficarum* (1486), whose author Heinrich Kramer came from Sélestat on the Upper Rhine, the coven is the witch-hunter's fantasy realized: a conspiracy of women against men and children. Read from 1976, it is the feminist utopia realized: an institution in which women hold authority over women, sustained by a symbolic order of their own.

The historical stakes of that fantasy should be stated plainly. The *Malleus* was a manual for the prosecution of witches: it defended torture in interrogation and argued that witchcraft was above all a crime of women. Between the mid-fifteenth and the mid-eighteenth centuries, ecclesiastical and secular courts across Europe executed, by historians' current estimates, some forty to sixty thousand people for witchcraft, roughly three quarters or more of them women, and the German-speaking southwest, Freiburg's region, was among the densest zones of persecution. Matilda Joslyn Gage's figure of nine million victims (1893) was a gross exaggeration, but her thesis that the persecution fell on women as women survives, in modified form, in Federici. The coven of *Suspiria* is a fiction set in a landscape of real executions, and the film's ambivalence toward female power is an ambivalence toward the figure in whose name those women were killed.

The witch had also been claimed, forty years earlier, from the opposite political pole. As Alexandra Kolb shows in her study of Mary Wigman's three witch dances (2016), völkisch and National Socialist writers cultivated the persecuted witch as a Germanic "wise woman" martyred by a foreign Christianity. Heinrich Himmler, whose SS security service compiled a vast card index of witch trials, claimed in 1944 that the persecutions had taken "hundreds of thousands of mothers and women of German blood"; Alfred Rosenberg propagated the image of the wise woman; Mathilde Ludendorff read the hunts as the patriarchal corruption of Germanic gender relations; and some women writers

of the movement already used the persecuted witches as figures of identification, anticipating, as the historian Felix Wiedemann observes, discourses of second-wave feminism. The witch that Italian feminists reclaimed in the 1970s had passed through völkisch and Nazi hands. *Suspiria*'s coven inherits both appropriations at once — a female sovereignty rendered as horror in a German city, under a figure the Third Reich had made a racial martyr and the 1970s a feminist one — and that double inheritance is a further reason the film cannot choose between dystopia and utopia.

The film does not choose between these readings, and that refusal is its political truth. It figures female power as monstrous in the idiom of the horror genre, which Barbara Creed would anatomize as the monstrous-feminine (1993). Yet it also figures female power as real, organized, and durable, in a decade when that reality was the stake of a political movement. The American girl who destroys the coven is not a male hero restoring patriarchy; she is a woman, and the question she poses is which kind of female authority survives — the archaic collective under a hidden Mother, or the individual who has learned its secret.

Federico Fellini's *Giulietta degli spiriti* (1965), his first color feature, had already imagined the occult as a woman's emancipation: a bourgeois wife, betrayed by her husband, frees herself through séances, visions, and the household of a sensual neighbor. Sandra Milo plays three roles: Susy, the neighbor; Iris, a spirit who becomes Giulietta's guide in the form of a whisper; and Fanny, a circus ballerina with whom Giulietta's grandfather once ran away. Among Giulietta's memories is a religious school pageant in which, as a child, she played a martyr on a pyre until her grandfather stopped the performance. A whispering spirit named Iris, a ballerina, a neighbor called Susy, and a schoolgirl on a pyre are all present in an Italian color film twelve years before Argento's. The names are a nonsensuous similarity in Benjamin's sense, not a source. The film's significance here is that Italian cinema of the decade could picture a feminine occult as release; *Suspiria*'s coven is the dark counterpart of that utopia, the same world of women and spirits organized as an institution of power. The first version of this chapter cut the comparison for length.

9.3 Germany and the inability to mourn

Alexander and Margarete Mitscherlich's *Die Unfähigkeit zu trauern* (1967) argued that postwar West Germans had defended themselves against mourning — for the millions murdered by the National Socialist state — above all some six million European Jews, together with Roma and Sinti, the disabled, and others — and for the lost ideal the Führer had represented — through derealization of the past and manic reconstruction. Eric Santner's *Stranded Objects* (1990) read the New German Cinema as an attempt to perform the work of mourning that the society had refused. Hans-Jürgen Syberberg's seven-hour *Hitler, ein Film aus Deutschland*, released in 1977, staged that work in a studio of projections and puppets.

De Quincey's Mater Suspiriorum is the visitor "of the Pariah, of the Jew," of the outcast and the enslaved. Argento places her in a German city. The academy's façade copies a Gothic house in Freiburg, a city whose old town was largely destroyed in the air raid of November 1944; its blind musician dies on the Königsplatz, the regime's parade ground (Chapter 7); and its occult knowledge is held by an aged German professor. The film never mentions the war. Its Germany is a place where

sorrow has been privatized into a secret society and the past survives as an unseen sovereign who sleeps in a hidden room. That is the inability to mourn rendered as a fairy tale.

West Germany entered its "German Autumn" on 5 September 1977, when a commando of the Red Army Faction kidnapped Hanns Martin Schleyer in Cologne, killing his driver and three police officers. Schleyer, president of West Germany's two main employers' associations, had been an SS officer: the unmourned past in person. On 13 October a Palestinian commando acting in support of the RAF hijacked the Lufthansa jet *Landshut*; its leader murdered the captain, Jürgen Schumann, and on 18 October the West German GSG 9 unit stormed the plane at Mogadishu. That night the imprisoned RAF leaders Andreas Baader, Gudrun Ensslin, and Jan-Carl Raspe were found dead in their cells at Stammheim, deaths officially ruled suicides and contested by their supporters; the next day Schleyer was found murdered by his captors. Luca Guadagnino's *Suspiria* (2018) set itself in Berlin during those weeks and made explicit what the original left latent. Its psychoanalyst, Josef Klemperer, mourns his Jewish wife Anke — played by Jessica Harper, the first Suzy — who was seized by the Nazis and died in the Theresienstadt camp; its academy is a company of German expressive dance; and its heroine is revealed as Mother Suspiriorum herself, who kills Markos and her loyal matrons, spares those devoted to Madame Blanc, tells the old man how his wife died, and then grants him the mercy of forgetting. The remake supplies the original with the mourning it withheld, and with an ending that resolves the original's undecidability in favor of inheritance.

9.4 Fascinating fascism and the hypnotic head

Susan Sontag's "Fascinating Fascism" (1975) identified the aesthetic of fascism in Leni Riefenstahl's work: the massing of groups, the conversion of people into things, the multiplication of identical units, and the grouping of all around an all-powerful, hypnotic leader or force. Riefenstahl had begun as a dancer, and made her screen debut dancing in Arnold Fanck's *Der heilige Berg* (1926). Gustave Le Bon's *Psychologie des foules*, published in 1895, the year of the academy's founding, had described the crowd as a mass held by contagion and suggestion under a leader's prestige; Mussolini professed admiration for it.

The academy is a crowd of this kind: identical students drilled in synchronized movement, held by suggestion — the hex, the wine — under the prestige of a leader no one sees. Its hidden sovereign is the hypnotic force Sontag described, and Pasolini's *Salò* (1975) had shown the same structure as an institution of torture organized like Dante's circles. *Suspiria*'s own aestheticism, its pleasure in ornamental death, runs the risk Sontag named: the spectacle may reproduce the fascination it depicts. The film's countermeasure is its plot. The hypnotic head is decapitated — pierced through the neck — by the one student who has refused the sedation, and the mass it held dies with it.

9.5 The queen's two bodies, and the priest of Nemi

Professor Milius states the coven's political theory: its strength comes from its leader, and without its head it perishes. Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) reconstructed the medieval doctrine that distinguished the king's mortal natural body from the immortal body politic, so that the

office survives the man: the king never dies, *dignitas non moritur*. The coven lacks that doctrine. Its body politic is identical to the natural body of an ancient woman, and when that body is pierced, the dignity dies with it — unless the dignity passes to the one who killed her.

Frazer opened *The Golden Bough* (1890) with the priest of Diana at Nemi, in the Alban Hills near Rome, who held his office until a successor slew him and took his place. Succession by killing is the oldest rule of sacred kingship in Frazer's anthropology, and it was located beside a sanctuary of Diana, Queen of Witches in Leland's Tuscan gospel. Carl Schmitt's *Politische Theologie* (1922) defined the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception; Markos governs as pure exception, officially absent and actually present, outside the academy's rules and their source. Read through Kantorowicz, Frazer, and Schmitt, the climax of *Suspiria* is a problem of sovereign succession. The incumbent dies at the hand of the challenger; the question is whether the office dies too, as Milius predicted, or passes, as Frazer's rule and Guadagnino's remake suggest.

9.6 Three feminist grammars of the Mother

The undecidability can be stated in the terms of three feminist theories of the mother, which the film anticipates without choosing among them.

For Julia Kristeva, the separation from the mother is the condition of subjectivity. *Pouvoirs de l'horreur* (1980) described abjection as the expulsion of what threatens the self's borders, and located its first object in the maternal body; *Soleil noir* (1987) called matricide "our vital necessity," the precondition of autonomy, whose failure produces melancholy. On this reading Suzy's act is health: she kills what she must leave, and the smile is the smile of a subject born.

Kristeva's title is Nerval's, and the first version of this chapter cut him for length. In "El Desdichado," published in *Les Filles du feu* (1854), the speaker names himself "le Ténébreux," the dark one, the widower, the unconsoled, whose lute bears "le Soleil noir de la Mélancolie," the black sun of melancholy; in *Aurélia* (1855) the lost beloved dissolves into a universal Mother who is Isis and Mary at once. Kristeva reads Nerval as the poet of a mourning that could not be completed, a subject held by the lost mother rather than separated from her. Nerval took his own life in January 1855, before the second part of *Aurélia* appeared. In the terms of this dissertation he is Mater Tenebrarum's subject, the one De Quincey's "suggestress of suicides" claims, and his title gives the third Mother her modern name. The contrast clarifies the stakes of the film's ending: Nerval is the subject who could not separate from the Mother and was consumed by her darkness; Suzy is the subject who kills her and walks out of the house. Between Nerval's daughters of fire and a daughter who leaves the fire lies the whole distance between melancholy and succession.

For Luce Irigaray, Western culture rests on a matricide more archaic than the parricide Freud placed at its origin in *Totem and Taboo*; in "Le corps-à-corps avec la mère" (1981) she located that murder in the killing of Clytemnestra by her son Orestes — Clytemnestra having killed Agamemnon, who had sacrificed their daughter Iphigenia — and in the court of Athena that acquitted him, silencing the mother's body and desire. On this reading Suzy repeats the founding crime of patriarchal culture in a woman's hand, and her success is a defeat.

For Luisa Muraro, whose *L'ordine simbolico della madre* (1991) grew from the Italian practice of sexual difference, the woman's access to language and authority depends on knowing how to love the mother — *saper amare la madre* — and on acknowledging a debt to her rather than killing her. On this reading the question is whether Suzy's act ends the maternal order or enters it, whether the smile is the refusal of the debt or its acceptance.

Feminist film theory supplies the spectator's position. Carol Clover's "Final Girl" (1992) survives by becoming, in effect, the hero; Linda Williams's "When the Woman Looks" (1984) argued that when the woman in horror looks at the monster she often recognizes a kinship, since both figure a difference that the patriarchal gaze cannot master. Suzy looks at the Mother in the flash of lightning and recognizes her. Whether that recognition is the recognition of an enemy or of an ancestor is the question the final smile refuses to answer — and the subject of the last chapter.

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PART FOUR · THE FURNACE

CHAPTER

X

Accomplished in the Furnace

Fire, Matricide, and the Smile

So shall he be accomplished in the furnace.

DE QUINCEY · "LEVANA"

Every Mother's house in the trilogy ends in fire, and the fire is the fourth element that completes the triad and the furnace in which De Quincey's commission is fulfilled; the matricide that sets it burning is a descent to the Mothers that succeeds where Faust's failed, and the heroine's final smile is the exhalation that answers the film's long-held sigh.

10.1 Fire in every house

Suspiria ends with the academy exploding and burning while its coven dies; *Inferno* (1980) ends with Mater Tenebrarum's New York house in flames; *The Mother of Tears* (2007) ends with the third Mother destroyed amid fire and collapsing masonry in Rome. Chapter 3 showed that the Mothers embody grief's three phase-states — liquid tears, aerial sighs, privative darkness — and that fire alone is absent from their constitution. Fire is the element in which each of them is unmade. Heraclitus called the world-order an ever-living fire, kindling in measures and going out in measures (B30), and held that all things are an exchange for fire, and fire for all things (B90). In the alchemical tradition from which Varelli's architecture descends, the furnace, the *athanor*, is the vessel of transformation, and calcination by fire is the first operation of the Work. De Quincey's Madonna had promised that her pupil would "be accomplished in the furnace." The trilogy takes her at her word.

The fire was already in the Mother's legend. The trilogy's lore holds that Markos, suspected by the townspeople of witchcraft as her wealth grew, staged her own death in a fire in 1905, ten years after the founding. The academy's history therefore contains two fires — a feigned death and a real one — and the second completes what the first only performed.



FIGURE 13 *Fire in every house: the three Mothers' dwellings and the element in which each is unmade.*

10.2 Literary fires

The burning of a witch's or a mother's house has a long literary history, and *Suspiria* condenses it. In the Grimms' "Hansel and Gretel," the girl tricks the witch into her own oven and burns her; the children walk home out of the forest with the witch's jewels. In Charlotte Brontë's *Jane Eyre* (1847), Bertha Mason, the first wife whom Rochester has kept locked in the attic for years, sets fire to Thornfield Hall and falls to her death from its roof as he tries to reach her; Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar read her as Jane's dark double, the rage the heroine cannot express (1979), and Jean Rhys's *Wide Sargasso Sea* (1966) gave the madwoman her own history as Antoinette Cosway, a Creole heiress married for her fortune, renamed Bertha by her husband, and carried to England to be confined. In Poe's "The Fall of the House of Usher" (1839), the sister whom Roderick Usher has entombed while she was still alive returns from the vault, and the house splits and sinks into the tarn.

Two German fires are closer still. Wagner's *Götterdämmerung* (1876) opens with the three Norns spinning the rope of fate until it snaps, and closes with Brünnhilde's immolation: she rides into the funeral pyre, the fire spreads to Valhalla, the gods' house burns, and the Rhine overflows to reclaim the ring. The *Ring* is framed by triads of women — three Rhinemaidens at its beginning, three

Norns at the start of its last part — and it ends in fire and water together. *Suspiria* ends the same way: the house of the Mothers burns and the heroine walks out into the rain. Novalis's Klingsohr tale in *Heinrich von Ofterdingen* (1802) is the other German prototype. The Scribe, the figure of a desiccated rationality, leads a revolt in the household and has the Mother burned at the stake; the little girl Fable descends to the underworld, where the three Fates spin, and overcomes them; the world is renewed, and the Mother's ashes are gathered so that all may drink them. A girl overcomes the three spinning sisters, the Mother burns, and her substance passes into those who survive her. It is hard to imagine a closer anticipation of the film's structure, and of the question whether the Mother's death is an end or a transmission.

Jorge Luis Borges's "Las ruinas circulares" (1940) adds the last literary term. A man dreams a son into being, protects him, and sends him into the world; when fire comes to the ruined temple, the dreamer walks into the flames and they do not burn him, and he understands with relief and terror that he, too, is an appearance that another is dreaming. Suzy walks out of the burning academy unharmed.

10.3 Historical fires

Two historical fires stand behind the fictional ones, and both belong to the constellations traced in earlier chapters. On 4 May 1897, at the Bazar de la Charité in Paris, a cinematograph's ether lamp ignited and the fire consumed the hall; some hundred and twenty-six people died, most of them women of the aristocracy gathered for charity. Cinema's first great catastrophe, two years after the Lumière premiere, was a fire that killed a gathering of women. On the night of 31 December 1922, the first Goetheanum at Dornach — Rudolf Steiner's wooden, double-domed temple of the arts, built in the border region that Argento named as the origin of his fascination, and the home of eurythmy — burned to the ground, in what was widely believed to be arson.

The cinema has never forgotten that its matter is flammable. Nitrate film burns, and films about cinema return to the fire: Quentin Tarantino's *Inglourious Basterds* (2009), whose director has never hidden his debt to Italian genre cinema, ends with a young Jewish woman setting her own cinema alight with nitrate prints while the leadership of the Reich sits inside. *Suspiria*'s furnace belongs to this lineage. If the academy founded in 1895 is an allegory of the cinematic apparatus (Chapter 8), then its burning is the apparatus consuming itself — the house of images ending in the element that has always threatened it.

10.4 The matricide

The final sequence, which the production record says came to Nicolodi in a dream, is a descent to the Mothers. The school has emptied for the Bolshoi. Suzy follows the remembered footsteps to Madame Blanc's office, recalls Pat's words, and turns the blue iris on the wall; a door opens. In the corridor beyond she overhears the teachers, led by Madame Blanc, plotting her death as a sacrifice; she hides in an alcove and finds Sara's mutilated corpse; pursued, she enters a bedroom and finds the Mother asleep, identifying her by her labored breathing. She breaks a glass peacock and wakes her.

The Mother makes herself invisible, taunts her, and raises Sara's corpse against her. Lightning shows the Mother's silhouette, and Suzy drives a glass quill through her neck. The corpse vanishes, the coven dies, and the building begins to explode.

The scene rewrites the most famous descent to the Mothers in literature. In the first act of *Faust II* (1832), Mephistopheles gives Faust a key and tells him to descend to the Mothers, who dwell beyond space and time; a glowing tripod, he says, will tell him that he has reached "im tiefsten, allertiefsten Grund," the deepest, the very deepest ground. Goethe told Eckermann on 10 January 1830 that he had found the Mothers in Plutarch, who records goddesses called the Mothers worshipped at Engyion in Sicily — and records, too, that a man of that town escaped his enemies by feigning madness sent by the Mothers (*Marcellus* 20). Faust touches the tripod with the key and returns with the phantoms of Helena and Paris, which he conjures at the Emperor's court like a magic-lantern show; when he tries to seize Helena, there is an explosion, and he falls senseless.

Suspiria keeps every term and reverses the outcome. A key — the iris — opens the way to the Mothers in the deepest ground of the house: *de profundis*. Helena is found there. The seizure of Helena produces an explosion. But the one who seizes her does not fall. She kills the phantom and walks out through the explosion. Where Faust, the man who wants to possess the image, is undone by it, Suzy, the girl who has been formed by the image-house, ends it.

Other mythic structures run through the same sequence. Perseus could kill Medusa only indirectly, seeing her in the polished shield Athena lent him; Suzy sees the invisible Mother only indirectly, as an outline produced by lightning. Orestes killed his mother and was pursued by the Furies until Athena transformed them into the Eumenides; Suzy kills the Mother, and the Furies — the coven — are not transformed but destroyed. *Suspiria* is an *Oresteia* without the third play: no court, no reconciliation, no cave beneath the Areopagus for the venerable goddesses, only fire. And Persephone, the daughter abducted into the house of the dead by Hades with the consent of her father, Zeus, returns to the light; but in the myth the Kore returning from below is also Queen of the Underworld, and the girl who comes back is not the girl who went down.

10.5 The smile

In the film's last image, Suzy stands in the rain before the burning academy, and she smiles. The smile has been read in several ways, and each of the frameworks assembled in this dissertation offers one.

As a *final girl*, in Clover's sense, Suzy smiles because she has survived. As a Kristevan subject, she smiles because she has accomplished the vital matricide and separated from the Mother. As the successor in Frazer's grove, she smiles because she has slain the incumbent and inherited the office, as Propp's last function promises an accession to the throne; Guadagnino's remake makes this reading explicit. As the fourth term of Maria Prophetissa's axiom, she smiles because the triad has been completed by the one who passes through fire, an assumption in the Jungian sense. As a counterpart of Rosemary Woodhouse, who at the end of *Rosemary's Baby* (1968) rocks the cradle of the devil's child with a faint smile of acceptance, she smiles because she has accepted what the coven made her. As Borges's dreamer, she smiles because the fire did not burn her, and she has understood whose dream she is.

The dissertation adds three readings of its own. The first is pedagogical. De Quincey's Madonna had promised that her pupil would "rise again before he dies" and that the commission would be accomplished, "to plague his heart until we had unfolded the capacities of his spirit." The smile is the sign that the curriculum is complete. Levana's rite, at its origin, was the lifting of the newborn from the ground to present its face to the stars; the girl who comes out of the furnace has been lifted. The second is meta-cinematic. Roland Barthes described the spectator leaving the movie theater a little numb, awkward, chilled, emerging from a hypnosis into the street (1975). Suzy leaves the image-house as the spectator leaves the cinema, into the night and the rain, educated or enchanted, and the film ends at the threshold where it began: she arrived at this door in a storm and was refused, and she leaves through it in a storm, alone. The knocking at the gate, denied at the beginning, is answered at the end from inside. Jessica Harper, who had played Phoenix in *Phantom of the Paradise*, walks out of the fire.

The third reading is pneumatic, and it is the one this dissertation proposes as its own. The film's sovereign was a sigh — a breath drawn up from beneath and held, sorrow suppressed into air. Its violence stopped breaths at the throat. Its final act stopped the breath of the Mother herself. What follows is not another sigh but its opposite. The Homeric Hymn to Demeter tells how the grieving mother, sitting in silence and refusing food, was made to smile and then to laugh by the jests of the servant Iambe, and how that laughter ended the first phase of her mourning. In the Valentinian myth, the fallen Sophia's laughter became the light of the world. The smile with which *Suspiria* closes is the exhalation of the held breath: the release of the *suspirium*. The film that began as sighs from the depths ends not on a sigh but on its exhalation.

The rest of the trilogy confirms this reading. *Inferno* ends with Varelli's nurse revealing, amid maniacal laughter, that she is Mater Tenebrarum, before she becomes Death and her house burns. *The Mother of Tears* ends when Sarah Mandy, the daughter of Nicolodi's white witch, strips the talismanic tunic from Mater Lachrymarum and throws it into a brazier; the lair collapses, a falling pillar impales the third Mother, and Sarah and her companion struggle back above ground and laugh, in horror and relief. Across thirty years the trilogy closes on breath released: the Mothers laugh as they are unmasked, and the daughters smile or laugh when the Mothers are gone. The exhalation is the trilogy's signature.

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CONCLUSION

Eductive Horror

Theses Toward a Levanic Cinema

...to plague his heart until we had unfolded the capacities of his spirit.

DE QUINCEY · "LEVANA"

Suspiria proposes, in the form of a fairy tale, a theory of the horror image as education rather than purgation. The ten theses below state that theory in general terms, so that it can be tested against other films and other institutions of terror.

I **On eduction.** The horror image can operate not by expelling affect, as in *katharsis*, but by drawing out capacity, as in *eductio*. Its paradigm is Levana's rite: the subject laid on the ground of terror and then lifted. Eductive horror is curricular. Its violence is arranged as a sequence of stations — dedication, seasoning, darkness, forbidden sight, the furnace — and its spectator occupies the position of a pupil.

II **On the Levanic institution.** Eductive horror tends to take the form of an institution of formation — school, academy, convent, company — whose visible pedagogy masks an occult one, and whose sovereign, like Levana, never shows her face and acts by delegation. The visible and the occult institution are not two organizations but one apparatus seen from two sides.

III **On pneuma.** The sovereign of eductive horror is apprehended by index rather than icon: by breath, voice, and trace. Its powers are those of Chion's *acousmêtre*, and its overthrow is a de-acousmatization. Because breath is the medium of its rule, its violence converges on the throat, and its death stops the breath on which its subjects depend.

IV **On matrices.** The image of eductive horror is matrical. It is produced by mother-forms and impressed on a receptive blank, and its subjects are enrolled — matriculated — in the Mother's register. In *Suspiria* the homology is material (three dye-imbibition matrices), narrative (three Mothers), and philosophical (Plato's *chora*, Goethe's Mothers hovered round by images of every creature).

V **On color.** Color in eductive horror is a chromatic Passion, light's suffering made visible in Goethe's sense. It functions as a *pharmakon*, sedating and waking at once, and the same transparencies that delight the eye become the blades that cut.

VI **On the apparatus.** The institution of eductive horror allegorizes the cinema itself. In *Suspiria* the allegory is carried by the founding date of 1895, by the dormitory scene that restages Plato's cave and Lewin's dream screen, and by the Mother who makes the dead move. Apparatus theory from Baudry to Kittler is its implicit commentary: the cinema is the mother's mouth become a machine.

VII **On the eye.** In eductive horror the gaze belongs first to the institution — the eyes in the dark, the watcher in the corridor — and the pupil's education consists in seizing it. The hundred eyes of Argus, set in glass, become the weapon that ends the invisible sovereign, and knowledge arrives as lightning, in Benjamin's sense: legible for an instant, and decisive.

VIII **On succession.** Eductive horror ends not in purgation but in a transfer, or a destruction, of sovereignty. Its climax is a matricide whose meaning hangs between Kristeva's vital necessity, Irigaray's founding crime, and Muraro's debt. *Suspiria*'s ending is undecidable because the conjuncture that produced it — Italy's returning witches, Germany's unmourned past — was itself undecided.

IX **On the palimpsest.** The apparent incoherence of eductive horror is the pressure of its strata. A palimpsestic reading, disciplined by the three grades of documented source, structural homology, and conjunctural co-presence, makes the incoherence legible without pretending to recover intentions, and without confusing a constellation with a cause.

X **On the exhalation.** Eductive horror ends not with the release of pity and fear but with the release of a breath held through the whole curriculum. *Suspiria*'s last image, a smile in the rain before the burning house, is the exhalation of the sigh with which it began.

The theory invites further work on three fronts. Within the trilogy, *Inferno* and *The Mother of Tears* translate the Levanic institution into architecture and the city, and they would test whether the

Mothers of Darkness and of Tears govern by other elements than breath. Guadagnino's 2018 film is the original's first great commentary: it resolves the undecidable ending in favor of succession, supplies the mourning the original withheld, and should be read as a reading. Beyond the trilogy, the genre's later films of dance, school, and mother — Lucile Hadžihalilović's *Innocence* (2004), whose girls are trained in a forest school after Wedekind; Darren Aronofsky's *Black Swan* (2010), whose dancer, governed by a controlling mother and cast in the *Swan Lake* of 1895, perfects herself unto death — suggest that the Levanic institution is a durable form. Finally, horror theory itself might add an eductive paradigm to its cathartic, abject, and corporeal models: a paradigm in which the genre's oldest scene, the school of terror, is understood as De Quincey understood Levana's, as "that mighty system of central forces hidden in the deep bosom of human life." In *Suspiria* that system has a house, a breath, a color, and a date. It also has an exit, and a girl who uses it.

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A NOTE ON SOURCES

This edition reproduces the dissertation after two verification passes. The claims most exposed to error were checked against the sources listed below, and the results were written into the text; the log is kept here so that a reader can see what was checked, and how.

The claims most exposed to error were checked against the sources below; one was corrected, one qualified, and several strengthened in the text.

CLAIM	CHAPTER	RESULT	SOURCE CONSULTED
Augustine names Levana as the power who lifts the child from the earth	1	Confirmed (*De civitate Dei* IV.11)	Tertullian, *Ad nationes*, annotated edition
The lifting was a paternal rite of acknowledgment	1	Qualified: modern scholarship favors the midwife's lifting; text revised	"Levana"
"Pneumatography" coined by Güldenstubbé in 1857	Introduction, 4	Corrected: the term is Kardec's (1858); Güldenstubbé first claimed the phenomenon (1857)	Kardec, *Revue spirite*, 1859
Three matrices and a receiving "blank" in Technicolor printing	5	Confirmed	American WideScreen Museum
Goethe's wording on blue	5	Confirmed; German now quoted	Goethe text, *Yearbook of German-American Studies*
Erasmus in the Haus zum Walfisch, 1529–1531; *De pueris* (1529)	3	Confirmed; dates refined	visit.freiburg.de
Freiburg's witch executions of 24 March 1599	3	Added	Historical Marker Database
Baudry's use of Lewin's dream screen	8	Confirmed; strengthened	Kessler, Utrecht; "Dream Screen"
Muraro, *La Signora del gioco* (Feltrinelli, 1976), and its method	Introduction, 9	Confirmed; content specified	*Storicamente* 4 (2008)
Sandra Milo's three roles in *Giulietta degli spiriti*	9	Confirmed; details added	Fellini Museum; Filmsite
The Mother of Tears: Elisa's voice, her wound to Markos, the ending	2, 4, 10	Confirmed; strengthened	"Mother of Tears"
	4, 10	Confirmed; strengthened	"Inferno (1980 film)">)

CLAIM	CHAPTER	RESULT	SOURCE CONSULTED
Inferno: Varelli's voice generator and death by it; Tenebrarum's laughter			
Augustine's Latin on Alypius	7	Confirmed; ear-before-eye passage added	Bibliothek der Kirchenväter
Markos's staged death by fire in 1905	10	Added (trilogy lore)	"The Three Mothers"
The wine regimen and the swimming-pool scene	4, 5, 7	Confirmed	Deep Focus Review; Christy Lemire

A second pass checked the six claims the first pass had left resting on the author's knowledge. All six were confirmed, and four yielded evidence now used in the text.

CLAIM	CHAPTER	RESULT	SOURCE CONSULTED
Goethe on *Purpur* ("Ernst und Würde … Huld und Anmut"); the purple glass and the Day of Judgment (§ 798)	5	Confirmed; quoted; strengthened	Goethe quoted in the Rudolf Steiner Archive; Paderborn digital library
The Grimms' *Erziehungsbuch* (preface to the second edition, 1819)	2	Confirmed; quoted; strengthened	German History in Documents and Images; Steinlein, Humboldt-Universität (1993)
Asa condemned by her brother, the Grand Inquisitor, in Bava's film	7	Confirmed	"Black Sunday (1960 film)">); ACMI
Dates of Wigman's *Hexentanz*	6, 9	Confirmed (1914, 1926); a 1934 group version and the Nazi witch discourse added	Kolb, *Dance Research Journal* 48.2 (2016)
Burdach named the amygdala	7	Confirmed; German *Mandelkern* and Klüver–Bucy added	Karl Friedrich Burdach; Engelhardt, *Revista Brasileira de Neurologia* (2017)
Hippolytus on the Eleusinian climax (*Refutatio* V.8.39–40)	7	Confirmed; wording and reference refined	"Eleusinian Mysteries," Encyclopedia.com

Statements still marked "reportedly" in the text — that the score was played on set, that the door handles were set at head height, Bergman's remark about the red soul, and Anna Bertha Röntgen's words on seeing her radiograph — rest on interviews and anecdote and are left as reported.



KEYWORDS

Dario Argento · *Daria Nicolodi* · *Suspiria (1977)* · *Thomas De Quincey* · *Suspiria de Profundis* · *Levana* · *Our Ladies of Sorrow* · *Three Mothers trilogy* · *Mater Suspiriorum* · *eductive horror* · *Levanic institution* · *pneumatology* · *pneumatography* · *acousmêtre* · *matrical image* · *chromatic Passion* · *Technicolor dye-imbibition* · *Goethe's Farbenlehre* · *chora* · *Bildungsroman* · *aesthetic education* · *Kleist's marionette* · *Romantic ballet* · *German expressive dance* · *giallo* · *Italian Gothic* · *female Gothic* · *fairy tale* · *triple goddess* · *comparative mythology* · *witchcraft historiography* · *Italian feminism* · *Trauerspiel* · *inability to mourn* · *matricide* · *sovereign succession* · *apparatus theory* · *palimpsest* · *constellation* · *Nachleben* · *1895*